



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

COMMUNICATION FROM THE PRESIDENT

Message on the State of the Nation by the President— [Col. 2]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 5]

STATEMENTS

- (a) Ghana Sports Fund— [Col. 15]
- (b) Terrorist Attack on Ghanaian Tomato Traders in Titao, Burkina Faso— [Col. 81]
- (c) Commendation of the Police and the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection for Rescuing a Stolen Baby— [Col. 119]

MOTIONS—

- (a) The Master Gas Agreement Between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd, Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 38]
- (b) Amendment for the Extension of Terms of West Cape Three Points between GoG and GNPC, Tullow Ghana Limited and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 38]
- (c) Amendment for the Extension of Terms of Deepwater Tano Petroleum between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 38]

RESOLUTIONS—

- (a) The Master Gas Agreement Between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd, Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 64]
- (b) Amendment for the Extension of Terms of West Cape Three Points between GoG and GNPC, Tullow Ghana Limited and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 65]
- (c) Amendment for the Extension of Terms of Deepwater Tano Petroleum between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd— [Col. 67]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 124]

Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Thursday, 19th February, 2026

The House met at the Chamber,

Parliament House, at 2:10 p.m.

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, we will take the item numbered 3, on the *Order Paper*. We have a Message dated 16th January, 2026 from the President through the Secretary to the President, Dr Callistus Mahama.

**COMMUNICATION FROM THE
PRESIDENT**

**Message on the State of the Nation by
the President**



**OFFICE OF
THE PRESIDENT**

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Ref. No. OPS 184/26/258

17/02/2026 16th February, 2026
5:51pm

**STATE OF THE NATION ADDRESS BY HIS EXCELLENCY
THE PRESIDENT OF THE REPUBLIC**

I write to formally inform you that His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana, will deliver the Message on the State of the Nation to Parliament in accordance with Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana.

2. Pursuant to the constitutional requirement that the President shall, at the beginning of each session of Parliament and before the dissolution of Parliament, deliver a message on the State of the Nation, His Excellency intends to address Parliament on Friday, 27th February, 2026 at 10.00 a.m. subject to your confirmation and the concurrence of the Right Honourable Speaker.
3. Please accept the assurances of His Excellency, the President of the Republic.

**CALLISTUS MAHAMA, Ph.D.
SECRETARY TO THE PRESIDENT**

**THE CLERK TO PARLIAMENT
PARLIAMENT HOUSE
ACCRA**

cc: The Vice President
Jubilee House
Accra

The Chief of Staff
Jubilee House
Accra

2:20 p.m.

The Speaker: Hon Members, before we go to the item numbered 5, I want to inform you that we have some visitors and they are with us at the public gallery. The visitors come from four institutions.

The first is Life Preparatory and Junior High School. They are 66 in number and the school is located in the Ashaiman Constituency. They are led here by their supervisor by name, Lovelace Mottey.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I want to warmly welcome them to this August House, their own House, for them to not just see, listen, but experience and feel what happens on the floor of Parliament in Ghana. Please, you are warmly welcome. Take advantage of your presence here to learn things that you may not find anywhere in the world. Please, you may resume your seats.

[Students of Life Preparatory and JHS were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: The second is from Education for Change and they are 32 in number. Education for Change is located in the Zabzugu Constituency and they are led here by the Executive Director, Ahmed Abubakari. The same goes with you. You are also warmly welcome and please, as I stated earlier, take advantage of your presence here to learn and experience something different. You cannot get it anywhere in the world. Please, kindly resume your seats.

[Pupils of Education for Change were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: The third is from Kesho Academy. They are 61 in number. They are located in the Anyaa-Sowutuom Constituency and they are led here by the Assistant Headteacher in the person of Theodora Dunku. Please, you are also welcome to Parliament House. I am happy you are here to observe how your parents conduct their business. So, kindly resume your seats.

[Students of Kesho Academy were acknowledged.]

The Speaker: The last is from the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies. They are 13 in number and the university is located in the Wa Central Constituency of the Upper West Region. It is mainly made up of student leaders, the Students Representative Council (SRC), together with the other executives and they are led here by the SRC President in the person of Manasseh Tetteh Armah. You and your delegation are also warmly welcome and you are better positioned to understand and appreciate what we are going to do here than your younger brothers and sisters from the basic schools. So, please, today is your day. You may not get the opportunity to be here again, maybe until you are struggling to be elected, to be a Member of Parliament. So, please, learn as much as you can and we also appreciate the distance you have taken to come down from Wa in the Upper West Region. You may resume your seats.

[Students of the University of Business and Integrated Development Studies were acknowledged.]

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT

The Speaker: We will start with the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* of Wednesday, 18th February, 2026. Page 1...7—

Yes, Hon Richard Acheampong?

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, page 7, item numbered 9, Mr Joseph Appiah Boateng was here with us yesterday but has been marked absent.

The Speaker: Table, kindly take note.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, page 7, item 5, paragraph 9(a), subparagraph 3 and 4. I want to draw your attention, with respect to some inconsistency, so that I seek your direction for the Clerks-at-the Table to correct them.

Mr Speaker, (iii), that is three, Ms Sena Bosson has been described as the Effutu Municipal Director of National Commission for Civic Education. When we proceed to the next one, she has been described as the Effutu Municipal Director of National Commission for Civic Education-Effutu. I think the inconsistency should be corrected.

Mr Speaker, if you may, a day before the *Votes and Proceedings* under review or consideration, the same person led a

delegation from the same Constituency, Effutu, and she has been described as a teacher. So, I seek your supreme direction or permission so that the Clerks-at-the-Table will find out from her the right designation, whether she is a teacher or director of Civic Education. Thank you.

The Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I thank the Hon Member for having an eagle eye to see all this. Table Office, kindly cross-check and let us get the right and appropriate title of the person involved. May I go on now?

Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni: Mr Speaker, on page 7, item numbered 4, the following Hon Members were absent. If we look at item numbered 5 on page 7, Mr Sampson Ahi was here yesterday and he even contributed during the Cocoa Board discussion but he has been marked absent—

The Speaker: Hon Member, I can see that your body language seems to be different from what you communicated to us. We want to hear you. We want to hear you because we are recording. What is your position now?

2:30 p.m.

Alhaji Alhassan Mumuni: I have abandoned the correction.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. Please, Hon Member?

Mr Emmanuel Kofi Ntekuni: Thank you, Mr Speaker. It is a minor one. On page 7 (a)(v), it reads, “Staff and Peoples of Crystal Gate”. Instead of “Gates”,

The Speaker: You said the gate is what?

Mr Ntekuni: Mr Speaker, it is “Gate” with no “s” from where I checked.

The Speaker: So, Crystal Gate; there is no “s”? Are you sure about that?

Mr Ntekuni: Yes, please.

The Speaker: Is that your alma mater?

Mr Ntekuni: Mr Speaker, no, please.

The Speaker: Clerks-at-the-Table, kindly cross-check on that and capture the appropriate name of the school.

Page 9...11—

Yes, Hon Member? No, your Leader is up, so I have to recognise him first.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, page 11, Question captured as 581. I recall the Deputy Minority Leader came under Standing Order 90(2), and sought the leave of the Speaker to withdraw the Question as captured. I see the Question has been advertised as having been asked. If the Table Office could effect the needed correction.

The Speaker: You are talking about page 11, 581 (c) or which one? The heading of 581, which is (b), says:

“the following Question was withdrawn by the Hon

Deputy Minority Leader and Member for Asokwa, Ms. Patricia Appiagyei, on behalf of the Hon Member in whose name the Question stood, pursuant to Order 90(2) of the Standing Orders.”

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am guided. Thank you.

Mr Fred Akyei Asamoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. My concern was with regard to that same item numbered (b), page 11. The Hon Member’s name, on the Question that was withdrawn, “Mr Francis Asenso Boakye”, Asenso-Boakye is a hyphenated compound name, so we are missing the hyphen.

The Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, page 2 captures the correct rendition. It is hyphenated. Table Office, kindly take note.

Page 12—

Mr Thomas Winsum Anabah: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I think the Table Office—just to make a correction in the spelling of my surname in item 295, “Anabah”

The Speaker: Please, pronounce your name again.

Mr Anabah: It is pronounced /anàabá/ and spelt “Anabah”. It has “h” at the end. I have always insisted on the “h”.

The Speaker: Initially, you said /anábá/.

Mr Anabah: They wrote “Anaba”. It must be spelt “Anabah” with an “h”. What is there is “Anaba”, so it must be “Anaba” with “h”.

The Speaker: What is there is not /anàabá/. “Anaba” cannot be /anàabá/. It is /anaba/. *[Laughter]*

Mr Anabah: Mr Speaker, the spelling should be with an “h” at the end. It is a surname, and it can be pronounced as best as one can. Thank you. *[Laughter]*

The Speaker: Exactly.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah —
rose —

The Speaker: Hon Member, why? Do you want to teach him how to pronounce his name?

Mr Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, I am a bit surprised that he does not even know how to pronounce his own name. *[Laughter]*

The Speaker: I know where he comes from, so I understand. *[Laughter]*

Please, Table Office, always add “h” at the end.

Hon Member, do you have any correction or, you are on a frolic of your own?

Page 13...17—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, with respect, just a minor observation. Item 3

(iv), I propose that before Francis, we delete the word and insert “Dr”. The Deputy Chief Executive Officer, Agronomy and Quality Control of COCOBOD is a holder of a PhD. I know that on authority. It is Dr Francis. *[Interruption]* This is not GTEC.

The Speaker: Table Office, kindly cross-check and do the right thing.

Page 19...23.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of the 10th Sitting, dated Wednesday, 18th February, 2026, is adopted as a true record of proceedings.

2:40 p.m.

The Speaker: We have two *Official Reports*. The first is dated Thursday, 12th February, 2026. Any corrections?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 12th February, 2026]

The Speaker: The second is dated Friday, 13th February, 2026. Any corrections? Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Afriyie: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I observed that at column 1, one of the very first things we do in the House is prayers. “Prayers” is conspicuously missing over here, even though it was observed on the said day because of what has been printed here. So, if that could be inserted.

Then, Mr Speaker, I respectfully invite you to column 87, paragraph 3 and 4. At paragraph three, “plans to implement the Black Star Experience in 2025”. I guess the year should be 2026. Consequentially, on paragraph 4, line 7, we delete the same “2025” and insert “2026”.

Mr Speaker, again, I invite you to column 112, paragraph 3, line 3 the name of my party, I mean the greatest party in Ghana, is National Democratic Congress. Over here, it is written as “National Democratic”, without the “Congress”, and then into brackets (NDC). I propose we insert the “Congress”.

The Speaker: Hon Member, with regard to your first issue, I see the “Prayers” on the second column. The first column just captured the Parliament, the fact it is the First Meeting, Friday, 13th February, and then the House met. But the second column starts with “Prayers”. Do you insist that we are wrong?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, that is why you are the faculty and we are the students. I have now seen it.

The Speaker: No, I am only the Speaker, I am not a faculty. Yes, Table Office, he is right on the rest. Kindly capture the right rendition.

Hon Members, there being no further corrections, the *Official Report* of Friday, 13th February, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as a true record of proceedings.

May we now move to the item numbered 6 on the *Order Paper*, Statements. Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: There is a Statement that is not advertised but admitted, and that is a Statement by the Minister for Sports and Recreation. So, I crave your indulgence for us to take a Statement on some major policy issues relating to our participation in the World Cup tournament.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader just mounted an application. But I want to advert his mind to the number of Statements that have been admitted and advertised. As of the last count, and you can help me count, there are 19 Statements advertised in the name of various Members of Parliament. Without any prejudice to our Minister, who we all respect, is he seeking to jump all the 19 and give preference to Hon Kofi Adams? Of course, all the other subject matter Statements are equally important. Today the Majority Leader was not at the meeting of the Business Committee. If he was at the meeting, he would have realised that we have over, as at the last count, close to 300 Statements and Members want to clear their throats, especially Members on their Side. I said Statements, I did not say Questions.

Mr Speaker, your Members want to clear their throats. They have Statements they want to speak to and he says we should sidestep all the 19 Statements because Hon Kofi Adams wants to make a policy Statement. I do

not know if he is coming under Order 91(2) or Order 93(1). His application does not find favour with us. At least, let us go by the chronology. If we look at the tall list, we have Hon Eric Edem Agbana, his Statement is first. I think we should be fair here. The Leader should wait and let me finish. I have not finished. He can have the whole day but he should let me finish. He is the Majority Leader, so any time he gets up, the Speaker will listen to him. With this little thing that I want to say, he wants to interrupt.

He has 19 Statements and most of them are on his Side, unless he is telling us he does not like the other Members. They also have to speak. Mr Kofi Adams just walked into the Chamber and he wants to make a Statement. No, he should join the queue. It does not find favour with us.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, if this House runs into problems getting to America, Canada and Brazil, we all know the source of the problem. The Minister wants to make a Statement on the World Cup. We all want to go to the World Cup, especially Hon Annoh-Dompreh. Just before we came here, he confided in me. No, I have not said what he confided in me about. Why is he rushing to assume that he confided in me about the World Cup? I just said he confided in me.

Mr Speaker, I think we can take the Minister for Sports and Recreation. It is not a long Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We will be charitable to him, but we will also appeal

that we should consider the others that have been advertised. At least when his Statement is made, we should consider the others that are also there. They have been there for a very long time and it is not fair.

The Speaker: Hon Members, I refer you to Order 67 so that in future we do not have these exchanges again. Order 67(1). When you go through it, you see that the word “Statement” comes at (r), and that deals with the Speaker. Then at (t), you have Statements by Ministers.

2:50 p.m.

Then you get to (ff), before you get to Statements by Members, so precedence and priority. The Statements by Ministers are to be given precedence over Statements by Hon Members for good reason, because we do so for Government Business. That does not mean that we are bound to do so. As you all know, these are just guides to our practice and procedure. So, the Majority Leader is quite right in calling us to take that one first.

My only challenge is that I have not seen the Statement. The Clerk just handed it over to me and the Minister is to read it. I will assume that his language will be parliamentary, because in presiding over it, if I come across anything that offends the code, rules, practice, or ethics of the House, then I will rule him out of order. It is not pleasant to rule a Minister out of order. So, I will plead with him that, as much as I am going to be gracious, he should

make sure he goes according to the rules, so that nothing will provoke debate. If it does, you do it as clearly stated by the Standing Order.

With this, Hon Minister, refresh your memory on Order 91, and you may proceed to read the Statement.

STATEMENT

Ghana Sports Fund

Minister for Sports and Recreation (Mr Kofi Iddie Adams): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity. As has been canvassed, Ghana has qualified for the 2026 World Cup. Funding will be a key component of our participation, and it is in that spirit that I make this Statement. Mr Speaker, I rise today not merely as a Minister for Sports and Recreation, but as a servant of a sector that has for decades operated with talent, passion and hope, yet without financial certainty.

Mr Speaker, on the 18th of December, 2025, exactly two months ago, this House did something historic. Parliament gave Ghana its first permanent statutory financing mechanism dedicated exclusively to sports and recreational development. Under the Leadership of His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, a promise was made that sport would no longer be treated as an afterthought in national development. That promise has been kept, Cabinet approval was secured, and Parliament passed the Bill. Presidential assent was granted, and the Fund now

stands as law, the Ghana Sports Fund, 2025 (Act 1159).

Mr Speaker, for years, we have all heard the same concerns: federations operate from crisis to crisis, athletes prepare for major competitions without assurance of funding, infrastructure is deteriorating faster than it is maintained and grassroots talent is lost because opportunity cannot be sustained. The Ghana Sports Fund was designed to end that cycle. But legislation alone does not finance sport; commitment does.

Mr Speaker, sport contributes approximately 2 per cent to Gross Domestic Product (GDP) in advanced economies. Globally, the sports industry exceeds US\$500 billion in value. Yet on our continent, sport contributes less than 0.5 per cent to GDP in most countries. Not because we lack talent and passion, but because we have not yet built a financing system that matches our ambition. The Ghana Sports Fund provides us with that system. It creates a structured, transparent and accountable framework to support infrastructure development, school and grassroots sports, elite athlete preparation, welfare systems, and recreation. It allows us to move from ad hoc allocations to creditable investment. It signals to the private sector that sport and recreation is not a favour; it is an industry.

Mr Speaker, I am happy to inform this august House that the first contribution to this Fund has already been made. The National Investment Bank (NIB) has demonstrated leadership with a donation of GHC100,000. That

gesture must not stand alone. It must mark the beginning of a national movement. In that spirit, I will donate two months of my salary to the Ghana Sports Fund, effective February 2026. *[Hear! Hear!] [Uproar]*

If we expect the private sector to invest, if we expect federations to reform, if we expect young athletes to commit, then leadership must also commit. I respectfully call on Hon Members of this House, Ministers of State and the Executive to support this Fund in tangible ways. The Government has delivered the framework. We must now collectively strengthen it.

I am confident that His Excellency the President, who made this reform possible, will continue to champion this Fund as its foremost advocate. To corporate Ghana, state-owned enterprises, financial institutions and development partners, this Fund offers a structured and credible platform for investment in youth, health, and national development. Do not wait for the Fund administrators to come knocking. Please knock on the Fund's door.

To the media and sports journalists across the country, I make a direct appeal. The same energy used to question sports financing must now be used to build it. Help us explain the Fund, help us hold it accountable and help us mobilise support. Campaigns succeed when information is accurate, consistent, and responsible. Mr Speaker, the Fund is not a one-discipline Fund.

3:00 p.m.

It is not a partisan fund; it is not a ministerial project; it is a national instrument. It is for the young girl in Tamale who trains without proper spikes. It is for the boxer in Bukom who needs medical screening and insurance protection. It is for the school athlete in Hohoe who has never travelled beyond her district but carries national potential. It is for our national teams who carry the flag of Ghana across the world.

Mr Speaker, this House has already made history by establishing the Fund. Let us now make history again by supporting it. Sports is not a sector on the margins. It is present in every constituency. As we often observe, no administration, no Member of Parliament, no community leader has ever built connection with the people without sports playing a role. It unites where politics divides. It engages where rhetoric fails. It inspires where policy alone cannot. We have established the structure. Now we must build a culture of contribution around it. If we get this right, the Ghana Sports Fund will not merely finance competitions, it will finance opportunity. It will finance jobs. It will finance national pride. It will finance long-term economic contribution and well-being. Let this House be remembered not only as the Parliament that created the Ghana Sports Fund but as the generation of leaders that funded it, defended it, and made it work.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: Hon Members, I think this is a very important Statement, well written and well delivered. It is your turn to make comments.

Yes, Majority Chief Whip, do you want to start?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, not at all.

Mr Speaker, we have agreed to take two comments on each Side and one each from Leadership to make it three. There are several other Statements. We have agreed on the proposal, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, it is so.

The Speaker: Two from each Side, but there are three Sides of this House. The only indication the independent Members gave was to do business with one of the Sides. They also do not make up a caucus, and that is the challenge. But because we say we will not leave anybody behind, we still have to consider their interests. They do not need to be a group; they just need to exist.

Yes, he caught my eye first so, I will take his comment first. Then on this Side, yes, this is my son; he loves football.

So, we start with Hon Dickson Kyere-Duah.

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for indulging me to join the

call to rally this honourable House and the entire nation for our collective and sustained support for the Ghana Sports Fund. The Minister for Sports and Recreation has passionately elucidated the benefits of the Fund. This Fund will serve as a very important vehicle for the transformation of sports in this country.

Mr Speaker, sports are a universal language spoken by people of all ages and it transcends boundaries: political, cultural, social and economic boundaries. In Ghana, sports are not merely a recreational activity. It is a very powerful tool for youth empowerment, for job creation, for international diplomacy, for building unity and peace among the people.

Mr Speaker, permit me to digress a little bit and look at the role of sports in achieving the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). If you look at Goal 3, for instance, it focusses on good health and well-being. Regular sports activities can reduce the risk of non-communicable diseases by up to 35 per cent, according to the United Nations. We also know that SDG 5 talks about gender equality. Sports empowers women and girls; it promotes inclusion and challenges all forms of discrimination and stereotypes.

Mr Speaker, despite the enormous benefits of sports, in Ghana, chronic funding challenges, lack of infrastructure and limited support for athletes have undermined the growth of sports in this country. It is therefore important for us as a House to show leadership in supporting this very important Fund.

This Fund is not intended to replace Government's responsibility; it is intended to complement our strategic partnership with the private sector to raise enough resources—

The Speaker: Hon Member, be mindful of time.

Mr Kyere-Duah: Thank you very much.

So, Mr Speaker, this Act is a creation of Parliament. It is therefore important that we as parliamentarians support, advocate for seed funding for this Fund and also play effective oversight to ensure transparency, accountability and management of this Fund. As has been shown by the Hon Minister, as a passionate football and sports administrator, I also donate one month of my net salary, to support this Fund.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for indulging me.

The Speaker: Hon Member, be specific, which month? *[Laughter]*

Mr Kyere-Duah: My net salary for the month of February 2026.

The Speaker: Thank you so much. So, first is the Minister for Sports and Recreation, February and March. Now we have another Member coming with February. Table, kindly take note and make sure that those salaries are sent straight to the Ghana Sports Fund account.

Yes, Hon Assafuah?

Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah (NPP — Old Tafo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. This is a challenge that I will pass.

The Speaker: I trust you. This tie is not for nothing.

3:10 p.m.

Mr Assafuah: It is a challenge that I will pass.

The Speaker: I trust you. This tie is not for nothing. *[Laughter]*

Mr Assafuah: It is a challenge that I will pass. *[Laughter]* Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably read by the Minister for Sports and Recreation. Let me indicate that this Sports Fund is one of the greatest milestones that has ever happened to the life of the sports fraternity. I say so because as the Ranking Member for the Committee on Youth and Sports, at the time that we were having deliberations as to whether or not to pass this Bill, one key issue that came to fore was about sustainability of funds for our sports fraternity.

Mr Speaker, until last year December, the sports fraternity has been limping. It has been struggling with funds. It would interest you to note that even this year, major competitions that we have—it is not only the World Cup. We have two other major competitions, but the Ministry of Sports and Recreation is struggling to even rake in funds to be able to support the World Cup. What that means is that we do not want this law to

risk being just a passed legislation without proper execution, without being able to rake in funds to support the Sports Fund. So, I will use this opportunity to call on all well-meaning Ghanaians to support the Fund.

Mr Speaker, secondly, just about some two or three weeks ago, the Committee also visited all the infrastructure that we have as far as the sports fraternity is concerned. We went to the Accra Sports Stadium and Borteyman. It was an eyesore. Maintenance culture at our various sports infrastructure is so bad to the extent that as Parliamentarians, as Committee Members, as people who are part of policymaking and, if you like, supporting policymakers, we have every responsibility to be able to support the Hon Minister and the Ministry of Sports and Recreation to be able to rake in funds in terms of having a strategic fund to be able to maintain all our sports infrastructure across the country. Accra Sports Stadium is not being maintained. In Borteyman, with the hundreds of millions that was used to construct this infrastructure, it is not being properly maintained.

So, it is important for us to be able to support the Ministry of Sports and Recreation to rake in a lot of funds to be able to support the Fund. Mr Speaker, as I initially said, I will pass the challenge. I know that the Hon Minister has already contributed two months of his salary. As to whether it is his salary from the Ministry or his salary as a Member of Parliament (MP), we are not aware. But as we speak, I am calling on all well-

meaning Ghanaians to support the Fund to make sure that we can go to the World Cup. Thank you very much.

The Speaker: Hon Member, I did not hear you. *[Laughter]*

Mr Assafuah: For those of us in opposition, we will pass that challenge.

The Speaker: Oh, you will pass on that challenge, or you will pass that challenge? — You will pass it by failure to be certain about your contribution? *[Laughter]*

Hon Members, I am very sure the Hon Minister has only one salary, and that is the salary he has promised to contribute. There is no MP's salary and Minister's salary. There is only one that he is entitled to. Yes, we would move on to the third contributor.

Mr Fred Kwesi Agbenyo (NDC—Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a comment on the Statement ably presented by the Minister for Sports and Recreation. Let me also add my voice to my brother, Hon Assafuah, when he says that one of the biggest things that has happened to this country, as far as sports is concerned, is the establishment of this Sports Fund.

Mr Speaker, I have always argued that the sports industry has the potential of creating job opportunities for all the young people that we have in this country. Because that industry is such that it can engage the services of almost every professional. People in the health

sector, academia, drivers, cleaners—everybody can get some work to do within the sports fraternity or industry when well taken care of. Unfortunately, over the years, we have not injected the needed funds into that particular industry.

Ghana is said to be the Brazil of Africa. The talent is here. But Mr Speaker, until you add value to the talent and until you develop the infrastructure, it will be difficult to match up with your colleagues in other countries. So, every now and then, we go for sports festivals, we see Ghana performing very well, but we are not able to get to the very top because we do not do the basic things we are supposed to do before we get to that level. Mr Speaker, even the sports academies that the francophone countries are developing today—with the exception of the few private ones we have in Ghana, we do not have a lot sports academies that will groom young people from the foundation level. So, I am very happy that this Fund has come. We can now use this Fund to improve on infrastructure, build more sports academies across the country, where we can unearth talent at the very beginning.

Mr Speaker, I wish that in every district in this country, we could convert one secondary school or one basic school into a sports academy and have a specialised curriculum for them to follow. People can go in there to pursue a course in refereeing, sports administration among others and climb all the way to the university level. So, this is a Fund that all of us must embrace. We must get the needed money to

support it. If government can think of maybe putting a percentage on either fuel, or any of our commodities, that can regularly contribute money to this Fund, I think it will help all of us.

Mr Speaker, I would not speak for long on this issue, except to say that the Hon Minister has paved the way. I am also prepared to sacrifice my one-month salary for the month of February, 2026 to support this particular Fund. I thank you very much for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

The Speaker: The last comment?

Mr Joseph Kwame Kumah (NDC — Kintampo North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to this laudable Ghana Sports Fund Act, 2024 (Act 1159). Mr Speaker, coming from the centre of the country, where Dogo Moro and Baba Yara hail from. I know the importance of sports and its infrastructural need. Mr Speaker, Kofi Owusu, Baba Yara and others left an indelible mark through sports in Ghana. My constituency, Kintampo North, is yearning for sports infrastructure. I cannot do anything better than contributing to this Statement, and to appeal that a lot of people follow to make this Fund a reality for the welfare of athletes and their development. Grassroots talents may be identified so that we poach the footballers at their young age. We can get athletes at their young age which will catapult into economic growth and youth empowerment.

3:20 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I am, by this, pledging GH¢30,000 to be paid over three months, GH¢10,000 per month. Yes, this is because the Kintampo North Constituency is so broad and the commitments are enormous. I would also appeal that I am making this passionate donation so that, in the future, any sports infrastructure can be thought of for Kintampo North. We need to leave a legacy for Baba Yara, Dogo Moro, Kofi Owusu, and others.

Thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

The Speaker: Hon Members, we now have to listen to the Leaders. We will start with the Minority Bench.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, may I draw your attention to the earlier agreement that there would be two persons on each Side, and then the Leadership. So far, three persons have spoken on their Side, and only one person, Hon Vincent, has spoken on our Side.

So, Mr Speaker, we have one more person who needs to speak, and then Leadership will speak.

The Speaker: Minority Chief Whip, actually, I counted the man in the black safari suit among your numbers. I am sorry.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, they have taken a lot of our seats, but we will reclaim them.

The Speaker: You can have a bite.

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Kintampo North): Thank you very much, Rt Hon Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me commend the maker of the Statement, the Minister for Sports and Recreation. The Minority may not have enough to contribute, so the Majority should not be too expectant. But we have the ideas to help shape what we want to do.

Mr Speaker, while I commend the Minister for Sports and Recreation for the two-month donation of his salary, I am fortified in my belief that by the end of proceedings, he might move to six months of his salary, as he is showing leadership by example.

3:23 p.m. — [HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER, MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you may continue.

Mr Awuku: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, while we commend the Majority Side for their generous contributions and donations, it is clear that it is symptomatic of the general conditions in the country. So while they donate generously, they should let us also see how we can make it work in this broader perspective.

So, Mr Speaker, I would like to reiterate the point I made earlier about the Ghana Sports Fund. I would like to

once again draw the attention of the Minister for Sports and Recreation to the fact that, beyond the donations from Members of Parliament and interest groups, one key sector that can help drive this Sports Fund is the private sector and corporate Ghana. I believe that the Minister for Sports and Recreation, working hand in hand with the Ministry of Finance, can have a framework where they can come back to Parliament with an arrangement where they can encourage the private sector and define it as much more beneficial to also support this Sports Fund. There is no doubt that this Fund holds the potential to help our sports sector and also help fill the infrastructure gap that we have by contributing towards its building and maintenance.

Again, I believe that when all sectors of our economy, from farmers to bankers to insurance institutions, are involved, including our cocoa farmers, when they also have what they are supposed to get, everyone can generously contribute towards this. But the last point that I would like to make and also emphasise is that it cannot be driven by just individual donations. That will not be sustainable because expectations from the sports fraternity, Mr Speaker, are quite huge and the task ahead for the Hon Minister, for me, will be to work hand in hand with all the stakeholders that I have discussed with him in confidence. I believe that by sharing that with the broader face of our country, people will find it much more engaging, get the media involved, get Corporate Ghana involved, and get the various stakeholders who can help drive it.

But on this note, I want to commend him for this Statement, and I believe that all of us are here to support him in this direction.

Mr Speaker, silver and gold I have none, but I have ideas to contribute. Thank you very much. —[Laughter]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, we are most grateful to you, and we are grateful for your contribution towards sports development.

Yes, Majority Leadership?

Mr Mahama Ayariga (NDC — Bawku Central): Mr Speaker, this is one instance where we will not accept a decision by the Minority Leadership not to say anything.

Mr Speaker, this is a Statement that is also a fundraising event. So we need to take more statements and more pledges. All I can say is that my Friends on the other Side are running away from contributing. The essence of the Statement is to appeal to all of us to endeavour to contribute to the Sports Fund – some support to breathe life into the Fund.

Mr Speaker, as we approach the World Cup tournament, we know there will be a lot of pressure in terms of resources to support the Black Stars and to support the various supporter unions who would want to go and support and cheer our team. I believe we all recall that there was a commission of enquiry that presented a report, a White Paper, the Dzamefe Committee. The report,

adopted by the Government, stated that state funds should not be committed to supporting certain activities in our tournament. The only lawful thing that state funds can be committed to is specifically financing the team to go and participate.

But we all know that a team alone cannot just go and participate and come back. The team does well based on a certain atmosphere. And so, there is a need to create an enabling atmosphere in the country where the team is participating in the tournament so that they can deliver.

I recall, Mr Speaker, that when I was Minister for Sports, we went to Equatorial Guinea for the African Cup of Nations. I had to commit a few days before the tournament to travel to some of the major cities in Equatorial Guinea to meet the Ghanaian community and convince them to leave their jobs and travel from their cities to Malabo and Mongomo, where we were playing.

3:30 p.m.

We also played in, I think, three cities, and wherever they went, we had to provide buses at the barest minimum. We had to buy tickets for them. A man who is working, and then we ask him to leave his work to support Ghanaians because we are not able to ferry Ghanaians all the way from Ghana to support them. So, we want to count on the small contingent of Ghanaians who are in that country to at least show up at the stadium to support. It will cost money, whichever way; no matter what sacrifices they choose to

make, we would still have to spend some money.

It might even be necessary to support our supporters' unions to go there. But the Report of the Commission states that the funds of the State should not be used for such activities. That is a very commendable position because of the abuses we saw in the past. So, we have to resort to raising funds through other channels to support the Black Stars and create an atmosphere in the various stadiums where they will be playing, in order to spur them on.

So, Mr Speaker, I think the Statement is very welcome, and I want to commend the Minister for Sports and Recreation for showing leadership. I wish it were across all Sides. I can see my Brother, the former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, during whose tenure, a lot of gold was mined in this country, by small-scale miners and large-scale miners alike. I am expecting somebody of his standing to urge Colleagues to contribute generously towards the Fund.

So, Mr Speaker, on that note, I would want to announce that the Frontbench of the Majority Side hereby commit their March salary to the Fund. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, I am also authorised by the current Minister for Roads and Highways, who used to be on the Frontbench; he has also committed to spend one month of his salary on the Fund.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, the Minister said two

months, and you are reducing it to one month?

Mr Ayariga: No.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: He said two months, and you are reducing it to one month?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is the Minister for Roads and Highways who is committing one month of his salary.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Ayariga: Yes. It is the Minister for Roads and Highways who is committing one month, as well as all of us at the Frontbench.

I think Mr Speaker will have the last word on this. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I also have the authority of the Minister for Finance, Hon Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, to commit one month of his salary to the Fund. But I can say on authority that my Chief Whip has decided to embarrass all of us. My Chief Whip says I should announce that he is committing three months of his salary. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, after that, I will invite the Office of the Special Prosecutor to come and find out how he was going to survive for the three months. From what sources of income would he survive for the three months? *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, let me commend the Minister for making the Statement, and thank all Colleagues who have

commented on the Statement. Also, to thank those who have generously donated, to inspire the rest of the country to follow suit and to also make some donations.

I think that the Minority Members can pledge. We know our salaries are the same; we receive the same salary. There is no Majority or Minority salary. So, we expect them to make some contribution to support the Black Stars. Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama is about to announce a contribution. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I think in addition to we making contributions, let us also urge our constituents, even if it is small amounts of money, through Mobile Money (MoMo). It could be GH¢10 or GH¢20; let us develop a culture of supporting the sporting sector. We like to watch television and enjoy football, but we must pay for it. It must be financed, so everybody must drop something in. After a while, the industry will begin to finance itself, when the industry picks up. Because it is a huge money-making venture and we need to push it to the point where it will be attractive to investors to enable it yield dividends. If we do not give it that push, we will continue to deprive ourselves of benefiting from the industry.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I thank the Minister for the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. Do we continue with the Statement?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is so. We want to take the first two Statements as advertised on the *Order Paper*.

Mr Speaker, my attention has been drawn to the fact that the Minister for Energy and Green Transition is here. His Business has been waiting for some time. So, I would want to plead with you that we vary the order of Business and take the Motion numbered 14.

Mr Speaker, the Reports have been laid and the Chairperson for the Committee is also ready. Mr Speaker, my prayer is that we vary the order and take the item numbered 14 quickly. Then we can come back and finish the other two outstanding Statements. Then we can move to the other Business as advertised.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, the application is to vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 14 at page 6 of today's *Order Paper*.

Mr Annoh – Dompreeh: Mr Speaker, we will not object to that application, but he prefixed his application with the fact that we will revisit the item numbered 6 and take the item numbered 6(b) chronologically in that order. I will rather defer on that, that when we take the Statement advertised in the name of Hon Edem Agbana, we should take another one on our Side. So, we can take the Statement of Hon Edem and then proceed to take that of any Member on our Side. We have a Statement from Hon Vincent and Hon Kabiru, so that we can have one apiece. So, Mr Speaker, we are in support. We can go ahead and take the item numbered 14.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is a very good suggestion. Once we are talking about Statement, let me use the opportunity to bring to the fore that it is for a good reason that if a Member has a Statement for the Speaker to admit, these Statements are transmitted to the Speaker through the Whips.

3:40 p.m.

Hon Members, this is very important. The reason being that, sometimes you have three to about five Statements on the same subject matter, coming from the same Side, when others could be reduced into comments.

Now, if you go by the practice and procedure, Statements should be channeled through the Whips, then they would have the opportunity to meet with their Members and indicate clearly to them that they all have Statements on the same subject matter. So that by agreement, they can let one person make the Statement and others will reduce theirs into comments. But if the Statement does not come through the Whips, they would not have the opportunity of knowing the nature of the Statement and whether or not they are all on the same subject matter.

Hon Members, by practice, let us try as much as possible to route the Statements through our Whips. Personally, I am not happy when Statements are given to me on the floor of Parliament for admission. I would not have the opportunity to read through the Statement and exercise the option within the Standing Order to either modify or not modify, to determine whether it will provoke debate or not. So, it is good Statements are transmitted through the various Whips. They would analyse the Statement and may also do some

modifications about it before it gets to me.

I plead with Hon Members to take note of this and follow the practice and procedure in transmitting Statements.

Secondly, when Statements are admitted, they are admitted for processing. After processing, it would end up being captured by the *Order Paper*. So, it is not my fault that you bring a Statement and it is not taken the same day. This is because, the Whips must process the Statement to be taken. So, I urge Hon Members to bear with us in this direction.

Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, we are grateful for your guidance and the directives given. I would relate with my Friend on the other Side accordingly and reach out to Colleagues as we should, so that we can all be carried along.

Mr Speaker, you have had many occasions to speak to us on the same subject matter in private. But for you to make an open statement, it must be a subject matter that you are worried about. We intend to deal with it as we should and to bring finality to this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I am most grateful.

Hon Members, the application to take the item numbered 14 has not been opposed. I will therefore call on the Chairperson of the Committee to move the Motion numbered 14.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I crave the indulgence of the House to take item number 14, Motions numbered 14, 16 and 18. They are all related and the Report that we would be submitting covers the three Motions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Chairperson, are your Reports contained in one document?

Mr Bedzrah: Yes, Mr Speaker, that is exactly what I mentioned. So, in that case, let me go back to say that you are moving the Motions numbered 14, 16 and 18.

MOTIONS

The Master Gas Agreement Between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd, Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

AND

Amendment for the Extension of Terms of West Cape Three Points between GoG and GNPC, Tullow Ghana Limited and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

AND

Amendment for the Extension of Terms of Deepwater Tano Petroleum between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Energy on the Master Gas Agreement between

the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, and PetroSA Ghana Limited (as Contractor Parties).

That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Energy on the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

That this Honourable House adopts the Report of the Committee on Energy on the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana

Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

Mr Speaker, with your indulgence, I will present your Committee's Report. I would request that the *Hansard* captures the entire Report as being read while I take the introduction, justification and the conclusion of your Report.

Introduction

Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited;

Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited; AND

Master Gas Agreement Among the Government of the Republic of Ghana (Represented by the Ministry of Energy

and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and GNPC Exploration and Production Company Limited (Explorco) and Tullow Ghana Limited and Kosmos Energy Ghana HC and Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited were *presented* to Parliament variously on 13th February, 2026 and 19th December, 2025 in accordance with article 268 of the 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana.

Pursuant to Orders 252 and 228 of the Standing Orders, Agreements were *referred* to the Committee on Energy and Leadership of the Finance Committee for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The Committee, acting together with the Leadership of the Finance Committee, met with the Hon Minister for Energy and Green Transition, Dr. John Jinapor, Hon Deputy Minister for Energy, Mr Richard Gyan-Mensah and a team of officials from the Ministry of Energy to consider the Petroleum Agreement. Officials of the Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Company Limited (Explorco), Tullow Ghana Limited, Petroleum Commission, Ghana National Gas Limited Company, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, as well as an officer from the African Centre for Energy Policy were in attendance to assist in the deliberations.

The Committee expresses its profound gratitude to the Hon Minister

and the Deputy Minister, Officials of the Ministry, Officials of GNPC, GNPC Exploration and Production Company Limited (Explorco), Tullow Ghana Limited, Petroleum Commission, Ghana National Gas Limited Company, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investment, and ACEP for their assistance during the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to and/or was guided by the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Petroleum Commission Act, 2011 (Act 821);
- iv. The Income Tax Act, 2015 (Act 896);
- v. The Environmental Protection Act, 2025 (Act 1124);
- vi. The Environmental Assessment Regulations, 1999 (L.I 1652);
- vii. The Petroleum (Exploration and Production) Act, 2016 (Act 919);
- viii. The Ghana National Petroleum Corporation Law 1983;
- ix. The Ghana Model Petroleum Agreement;

- x. Local Content & Local Participation Regulations L.I 2221;
- xi. The Petroleum Exploration & Production (Measurement) Regulations, 2016 (L.I. 2246);
- xii. The Petroleum Exploration & Production (Data Management) Regulations, 2017 (L.I 2257);
- xiii. The Petroleum Revenue Management Act 2011 (Act 815); and
- xiv. The Petroleum Revenue Management (Amendment) Act 2015 (Act 893)

Background Information

The State, GNPC and the Contractor Parties signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) on 3rd June, 2025 and 19th December 2025 to agree to the conditions under which the Terms of the WCTP and DWT Petroleum Agreements would be extended respectively, from 2034 and 2036 to 31st December, 2040.

The MoU among others contained the commitment of up to US\$2 billion of additional investments in the two contract areas by the DWT/WCTP Contractor, which will include the drilling of at least 10 and up to 20 new wells with the development of necessary subsea infrastructure to support continued oil and gas production in the Jubilee and TEN Fields.

Following the signing of the MoU, GNPC and the Contractor Parties engaged to negotiate the following:

Amendments to the West Cape Three Points (“WCTP”) and Deepwater Tano (“DWT”) Petroleum Agreements provide for extension of their Terms to 31st December 2040.

Master Gas Agreement: Given the Contractor’s commitment to increase gas supply to the State and the outstanding debts to the contractor for gas supplied, the DWT/WCTP Contractor Parties have requested that the Government of Ghana provides a robust payment security to underpin the obligations of GNPC under the GSAs, to justify further investment and continued supply of gas necessary to support domestic power generation.

The Master Gas Agreement provides, among other things a Corporate Income Tax (“CIT”) offset option to the DWT/WCTP Contractor Parties as a security that underpins the Gas Sales Agreements.

The Greater Jubilee Full Field Development Plan (GJFFDP) Addendum: As part of the implementation framework, the Contractor Parties are committed to updating the existing field Plan of Development and Operation, which will detail the work scopes for the additional investment required. The Joint Venture Parties are currently preparing the updated Plan of Development for consideration and approval by the

Minister of Energy and Green Transition.

The implementation of the framework will, among other benefits, reduce gas price by 18 per cent, increase gas volumes from 100 mmscfd to 130 mmscfd with the potential of adding another 50 mmscfd, increase GNPC's interest by an additional 10 per cent in each PA, and improve GNPC's capacity to systematically take over operations and build the capacity of other institutions within the sector.

Justification

The proposed extension of the West Cape Three Points and Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreements to 31st December, 2040 is justified on the grounds of safeguarding continuity of upstream petroleum operations and sustaining production in mature fields. The existing Contractor Parties possess extensive operational knowledge of the Jubilee and TEN Fields, and continuity under the current arrangements will minimise transition risks, preserve institutional memory and prevent disruptions in production that could arise from premature licence termination or operator replacement.

The extension is further justified by the substantial investment commitments tied to the revised contractual framework. The proposed amendments are expected to unlock up to Two Billion United States Dollars in additional capital expenditure, including the drilling of new wells and deployment of

supporting subsea infrastructure. These investments are critical to arresting natural production decline, stabilising oil output and enhancing gas recovery, thereby maximising the economic life of the fields and improving long term petroleum revenues to the State.

The Amendment for the Extension of the terms of the West Cape Three Points (WCTP) and Deepwater Tano (DWT) Petroleum Agreements will give the GNPC additional 10 per cent interest effective 20th July, 2036 resulting in a total interest of 22.5 per cent and 25 per cent for the WCTP and DWT agreements respectively.

The value to Ghana from the extended field life is projected to yield about US\$374 million to the State from increased production volumes and prolonged revenue flows and about US\$255 million of that realized in gas savings.

The Contractor's request for a Corporate Income Tax (CIT) offset as a Government-backed payment security guarantee for gas sales to GNPC stems from the need to find a lasting bankable solution to the debts that the state continues to owe the Contractor for gas supplies. As at the end of November, 2025, an amount of *One Hundred and Sixty-five Million, One Hundred and Fifty-One Thousand, Six Hundred and Seventeen United States Dollars (US\$165,151,617)* was owed under the Jubilee Gas Sale Agreement

(GSA) covering a period of about fifteen months. The proposed Corporate Income Tax offset provides a non-interest bearing, fiscally efficient and legally structured payment security mechanism that directly underpins Ghana National Petroleum Corporation obligations under the Gas Sales Agreements. Unlike letters of credit or commercial borrowing, the offset mechanism does not attract financing costs and does not introduce additional debt exposure. It leverages existing petroleum revenue flows while maintaining transparency and predictability in fiscal management.

The natural gas supplied under the GSAs constitutes more than twenty-five per cent of Ghana's requirements and is critical to the country's power needs.

Additionally, gas under these GSAs is sold at a price which is significantly less than other domestic and/or international sources.

In compliance with the Petroleum Revenue Management Act 2011 Act 815, the Ministry of Finance has undertaken to pay any Corporate Income Tax amounts offset by Contractor Parties into the Petroleum Holding Fund within sixty calendar days at the end of the relevant fiscal quarter. This ensures continued adherence to statutory petroleum revenue management requirements while enabling uninterrupted gas supply and sustained upstream investment.

Stakeholder Input

The African Centre for Energy Policy raised concerns regarding the proposed extension of the West Cape Three Points and Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreements to 31st December 2040, noting that the existing agreements still have substantial remaining tenure. The Centre questioned the necessity of early extension and requested clearer justification demonstrating why the proposed additional investments could not be undertaken within the existing contract periods. ACEP further called for a transparent comparison of projected benefits to the State under the extension scenario against outcomes that would arise if the agreements were allowed to run to expiry, including consideration of asset reversion and alternative development options.

Regarding the proposed Corporate Income Tax offset mechanism, ACEP cautioned that the arrangement raises statutory concerns under the Petroleum Revenue Management Act, particularly the requirement for corporate income tax receipts to be paid into the Petroleum Holding Fund. The Centre warned that reliance on a tax offset as a payment security mechanism risk weakening fiscal discipline within the gas-to-power value chain, undermining the effectiveness of the cash waterfall mechanism, and entrenching inefficiencies that have contributed to persistent payment arrears.

ACEP further highlighted risks relating to investment performance and fiscal exposure, noting prior instances

where costs were recovered despite under delivery on production outcomes, with adverse implications for national revenue. The Centre emphasized the need for enforceable investment milestones, clear safeguards against downside risk, and caution against creating a precedent that could prompt similar demands from other petroleum contractors, thereby expanding fiscal exposure across the sector.

Observation and Recommendations

Amendments to the Petroleum Agreements

Protection of Petroleum Revenues

The Committee noted that the Agreement expressly provides that all CIT amounts subject to offset shall be paid into the Petroleum Holding Fund in accordance with the Petroleum Revenue Management Act, 2011 (Act 815). This provision safeguards petroleum revenues and ensures compliance with the statutory framework for managing petroleum revenues.

The Committee thus recommends to the Ministry of Finance to religiously abide by the arrangement so as to ensure the continuous integrity of the petroleum revenue management regime.

Justification for an Early Extension of Petroleum Agreements

The Committee observed that while the Memorandum justifies the proposed extension of the West Cape Three Points and Deepwater Tano Petroleum

Agreements to 31st December, 2040 based on unlocking up to Two Billion United States Dollars in investment and addressing declining production, including a reported forty-six per cent decline between 2019 and October 2025, the remaining tenure under the existing agreements had not been fully exhausted.

The Committee further noted that the Memorandum did not sufficiently demonstrate why the proposed investments could not be undertaken within the current contractual term, nor did it clearly establish the investment constraints necessitating an early extension.

It was however explained to the Committee that there is the need for a 'breathing period' for investments before returns begin to be yielded. Early extension of the Agreements therefore allows for adequate time for the necessary arrangements to be made and for finances to be raised.

Master Gas Agreement

Pricing and Costing Implications

The Committee was informed that gas supplied under the Agreement is priced significantly below comparable domestic and international gas sources, and that the Contractor Parties have further agreed to reduce the cost upon the coming into force of the Agreement. The Committee considers this concession beneficial to the State, particularly in the context of energy affordability and power sector sustainability.

The Committee noted that upon ratification by Parliament, the reduced gas price will take immediate effect.

Waiver of Interest and release of tax liability

The Committee observed that Contractor Parties have waived the right to claim interest on amounts offset, and that valid offsets constitute full discharge of both gas payment obligations and corresponding CIT liabilities. The Committee found this to be a balanced risk-sharing arrangement, provided it is transparently implemented and properly accounted for.

Some Members were however concerned of the treatment of Corporate Income Tax in respect of gas sales under the Agreement, particularly regarding the protection of the State's fiscal interest.

Clarity of agreement duration and enforceability of supply volumes

Members expressed concern that framing the arrangement as being in effect for as long as gas is sold could create uncertainty regarding duration and endpoints. Members also raised concerns about the use of terms indicating that parties shall endeavour to supply certain volumes, and requested greater certainty regarding supply commitments and benchmarks.

The Committee recommends that the agreement documentation should provide clearer duration parameters, aligned to the underlying Petroleum

Agreement tenure and the proposed 2040 horizon, with explicit provisions for review. The Committee further recommends that supply commitments be supported by clear technical assumptions and transparent forecasting, with defined mechanisms for addressing supply shortfalls, including reporting, remediation steps, and escalation pathways.

Fiscal discipline and risk of moral hazard

It was noted that the Memorandum justifies the offset mechanism on the basis that it avoids interest costs associated with letters of credit or bank financing. However, Hon. Members were concerned about the risk of the mechanism weakening payment discipline across the gas-to-power value chain and create expectations of government absorption of commercial risk, thereby perpetuating structural inefficiencies.

The Committee recommends that the implementation framework should include clearly articulated performance improvement measures across the gas-to-power value chain, including enforceable timelines for arrears reduction, enhanced billing and collection systems, and institutional accountability measures. The Committee further recommends that any continuation of the offset mechanism be conditional on demonstrable improvements in payment performance.

Conclusion

The Committee has examined the proposed amendments relating to the extension of the terms of the West Cape Three Points and Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreements, as well as the Master Gas Agreement. In the course of its deliberations, some Members raised concerns regarding the use of Corporate Income Tax (CIT) as security in relation to gas sales under the Agreements, and the implications thereof for safeguarding the interests of the State.

The Committee notes that the Agreements ensure continuity in production and enhances investment in the sector.

The Committee therefore recommends to the House to adopt this Report and ratify by resolution:

Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited;

Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green

Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited; AND

Master Gas Agreement Among the Government of the Republic of Ghana (Represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and GNPC Exploration and Production Company Limited (Explorco) and Tullow Ghana Limited and Kosmos Energy Ghana HC and Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and Petrosa Ghana Limited; in accordance with Article 268 of the 1992 Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Chairperson, the *Hansard* has captured it, so do the needful.

3:50 p.m.

Mr Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Motion ably moved. Any seconder?

Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr George Kwame Aboagye): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion for the ratification of the agreement between the Government of

Ghana represented by GNPC and its subsidiary Explorco, Tullow Ghana Limited, Cosmos Energy Ghana and Petro SA Ghana Limited.

Mr Speaker, we in the Minority fully support the Agreement which has been submitted to this august House, but with a concern which we raised at the Committee level that they should look at the Agreement, especially with the extension of the Agreement. The existing contract is supposed to end in 2034 and 2036. The extension is up to 2040 and before this, existing contract was in place, (Act 919) was not in place at then. So, we the Minority expect that once we have got the opportunity for any extension or amendment, we have to factor (Act 919) into the contract. Why do I say so? (Act 919) talks about carried interest of 15 per cent. The existing contract carried interest is 10 per cent. So why do we not factor (Act 919)?

Mr Speaker, but we are made to understand that since they are coming to inject about US\$2 billion capital into this, and then with a drilling of 10 to 20 wells, they need to recoup their investment before they do that. But at 2036, they are going to increase the carried interest to 20 per cent. By 2036, the end of the productive livelihood of these hydrocarbons will be declining by then. So, that has been one of our concerns.

Mr Speaker, the second concern deals with the Gas Sales Agreement (GSA). With the GSA, we are going to offset the debt with Corporate Income Tax and our worry is, are we not opening

the flood gates for other entities to also ask the state for a security guarantee of the Corporate Income Tax whenever the state has an agreement with them, which is a major issue. We raised this issue but the Minister was able to explain to us. The Minority Side wants the House to look at these two concerns. For not opening the flood gates for other entities to also be on the Government to also factor (Act 919) in future agreements.

Mr Speaker, with these two concerns, the Minority supports the ratification for this Agreement. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very good observations. Thank you very much.

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC—Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Mr Speaker, thank you. As I rise to contribute to this Motion before us, the Agreement between GNPC as has already been indicated, Tullow Ghana, Cosmos Energy, and investment Petro SA Ghana Limited.

Mr Speaker, I believe that this extension could not have come at a better time than now as we strive to ensure energy stability, especially with regard to gas production. The intention of this Government has been clear from day one that gas is a just energy that must be pursued because it saves this country a lot of money. I am very happy about this Agreement because of the immense benefits it brings to this great country. On page 5 of the Report, paragraph 4.5, I want to highlight some of the importance we would get from this. This Agreement

is sure to reduce gas price by 18 per cent and increase gas volume from 100 million scaffolds to 130 million scaffolds with the potential of adding another 50 million scaffolds of gas, which will increase GNPC's. Another thing that is worth noting is that GNPC's interest is increased by an additional 10 per cent in this Agreement, bringing the total to 22.5. I think we need to commend the partners for this benefit that it is bringing to this country.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about an injection of US\$2 billion and a drilling of at least 10 wells. The benefits in the gas value chain that we stand to gain from this Agreement is one that we can celebrate. Most importantly, for the records, this country stands to benefit. The extended field life is projected to yield US\$374 million dollars to this state—[Hear! Hear!]*—*and increase production volumes and prolonged revenues in about US\$255 million dollars in support of gas savings.

Mr Speaker, I believe there is enough justification to support this Agreement and I plead and call on both Sides of the House to support this Agreement which would eventually yield to the benefit of this great country of ours. [Hear! Hear!]*].*

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP—Takoradi): Mr Speaker, thank you for this great opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I believe that as the position was mentioned by the Ranking Member, this Side virtually supports this project. We know for a fact that not until

2036, Ghana will still hold 10 per cent. It is only after 2036 that we would get an additional 10 per cent and then we have a paid interest of 2.2 if we have the money to pay for it. So, we should not box it up and make it look as if we are getting 22 per cent immediately. This will happen after 2036.

Mr Speaker, the other issue is that the investment that is going to be made is about US\$2 billion and we know that the gold that is sold in this country, small scale mines alone, is 10 billion. So, I believe that the investment they are going to make is not anything extraordinary and I want us to start having this mindset that we should start looking at the possibility of Ghanaians handling these investments and making those moneys for this country in full.

4:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if we also look at some of the gains that they said we are going to get, that comes to about US\$374 million. Mr Speaker, if we compare US\$374 million to US\$10 billion, clearly, it is nothing to write home about. Therefore, I believe that we should look at the possibility of Ghanaians doing this on our own, or if it is not GNPC, other Ghanaians raising the money to do this investment. We all know that it was not until 2007 when oil was discovered in Ghana. At that time, Ghana had not discovered oil. But currently, Ghana has been de-risked; therefore, anybody investing in this country knows that the possibility of discovering oil is high. Therefore, the negotiations, I believe that even though we are negotiating

something that is starting today, gives a lot of advantage to the Tullow, Kosmos and to PetroSA in negotiating now. If they had waited until the end of their agreement, naturally, other persons would have come in and maybe given us a better offer. I believe that we should still look at this possibility, and not wait until our hands are tied. Currently, as we speak, they are negotiating from a position of strength, and we are negotiating from a position of weakness. This is because if somebody is buying something from us today, something that we need in 2040, clearly, we should understand, 14 years from now, we are virtually not negotiating from a position of strength. I believe that these are some of the issues that we need to look at.

In concluding, I believe that with the additional drilling of the 10 wells, environmental issues are supposed to be looked at. Now that we have Environmental, Social and Governance (ESGs) frameworks, I believe that we need to be monitoring and evaluating the situation going forward. Mr Speaker, a lot of the coastal towns in Ghana, especially in the Western Region, keep complaining about the investments that have come into their localities because of the oil and gas exploration and the oil and gas companies. I believe that we should take advantage of this opportunity to ask for more for our local communities across the length and breadth of the country in support of this agreement.

With these few words, as our Minority Caucus said, we all support this project. I believe that after 2040, all the

oil and gas companies that have cited their headquarters in Accra, after making so much money, should now take the bold step to relocate back to the Western Region. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, I would like to yield to Hon Boamah-Nyarko. Thank you.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP—Effia): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to comment on this Agreement before this House. First and foremost, this is the first time in the history of our oil and gas industry that we have had the opportunity to do an extension of a Petroleum Agreement in Ghana. It is a novel opportunity that we have been faced with as a country. The first critical question one would want to ask is that the original agreement is supposed to terminate in 2034 and 2036; we are in 2026. So, ordinarily, the lifespan of the fields has about eight to ten years to exhaust. The question as to the basis upon which we want to do an extension up to 2040 requires us to go back to the Petroleum Exploration and Production Act 2016 (Act 919), which gives the Minister of Energy, when there is an expiration of a contract or a Petroleum Agreement, two options. The first option is for the Minister of Energy to trigger an extension after negotiation, or create a new Petroleum Agreement for the benefit of this country. Now, the Minister of Energy has opted for extension of the period. So, the question

is, what does Ghana stand to benefit from this extension?

The Report indicates that there is going to be an investment, an additional investment of US\$2 billion, which cumulative benefit to Ghana beyond the investment is about US\$340 to our economy. But the critical part I want us to focus on is that GNPC is our national oil company, and GNPC was created to do commercial production or to enter into commerciality in terms of the oil and gas. Why are we not giving opportunity for GNPC, with its capacity since 2007-2010 when we started oil exploration, to be the agency to take over these oil companies when their period expires? GNPC has built enough capacity to be able to do this work once the contract of these Petroleum Agreements expires. The Minister of Energy, for whatever good reason, is looking at an extension. But the country should take advantage of these Petroleum Agreements that expires to give it to our indigenous national oil company like GNPC to continue with these blocks so that at the end of the day, Ghana will get all the benefits. Now, we are already in production. This is not an exploration process. We are already in production, so the cost of investment is not the same as doing exploration. So, let us take advantage of our national oil company, which is GNPC and Explorco to do this particular investment.

Mr Speaker, the second area that raises concern for the Minority is the issue of the Corporate Income Tax (CIT) offset. How does CIT arise in the first place? A company makes a profit, and the tax authority taxes it, and then they

have to go and pay your CIT. Now, if the companies have to pay their CIT, which is supposed to be received by the Government of Ghana, yet because of other bodies' inefficiencies, they cannot honour their Gas Agreements, and we are asking Government to use CIT to offset those debts that are owed by Government agencies, then we are supporting inefficiency. This is because the CIT is supposed to be revenue generated to the State for the State to determine how it is going to be used when it hits the Petroleum Holding Fund (PHF). But here is the case, we are creating avenues for people to use inefficiencies in terms of their management to be able to offset taxes that are legitimately due to the State.

Mr Speaker, having looked at all of this, we are saying that as of 2025, Government was owing US\$165 million to these Jubilee partners in the oil and gas sector. What has the Minister done in recovering or making sure that these debts are paid, rather than looking into CIT to offset? Yes, this House has been invited. The agreement in its entirety, intent and purposes, as a Minority, we are raising the concerns or we approve that this agreement should go. But the teething matters that have been raised, such as building the capacity of GNPC to be able to take over the expiration of Petroleum Agreements so that we can maximise all the revenue benefits and also making sure that we do not leverage on inefficiencies of State bodies to offset taxes, to offset legitimate taxes that should go to the State. This Parliament

can accommodate it for now, but I am calling on both Sides to be mindful that we do not set this precedent.

4:10 p.m.

Because once we have done it, it is easy for any corporate or international body that has issues with government agencies to say that we did it for the Jubilee partner and we did it in the oil and gas industry, so we should continue to use government revenue to offset taxes, which is a bad precedent we are setting. Mr Speaker, without more, I want to say that for the Minority Side as my Ranking Member and others have commented, it is an agreement Government has chosen to extend. We had various options of giving it to GNPC to take over instead of giving them an extension. Also, the largesse that we are giving them is of concern. But we will take it in good faith knowing that in future, the House, both the Majority and Minority, will consider some of the issues raised. I want to thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is now the turn of the Majority Frontbench.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we do not have anything to say.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Consequential Resolutions. Are we moving Resolutions numbered 15, 17,

and 19 together as we did for the Motions?

RESOLUTIONS

Master Gas Agreement between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd, Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr John Abdulai Jinapor): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

WHEREAS

1. By the provisions of Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, any transaction, contract or undertaking involving the grant of a right or concession by or on behalf of any person or body of persons howsoever described, for the exploitation of any mineral, water or other natural resource of Ghana made or entered into after the coming into force of the Constitution is made subject to ratification by Parliament;
2. In pursuance of the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, the Government of Ghana has caused to be laid before Parliament through the Ministers responsible for Finance and Energy and Green Transition, the Master Gas Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Energy and Green

Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, and PetroSA Ghana Limited (as Contractor Parties).

NOW THEREFORE, this House in accordance with the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution hereby resolve to ratify the said Master Gas Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments, and PetroSA Ghana Limited (as Contractor Parties).

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Amendment for the Extension of Terms of West Cape Three Points between GoG and GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

Mr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

WHEREAS

1. By the provisions of Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, any transaction, contract or

undertaking involving the grant of a right or concession by or on behalf of any person or body of persons howsoever described, for the exploitation of any mineral, water or other natural resource of Ghana made or entered into after the coming into force of the Constitution is made subject to ratification by Parliament;

2. In pursuance of the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, the Government of Ghana has caused to be laid before Parliament through the Minister responsible for Energy and Green Transition, the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three Point Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

NOW THEREFORE, this House in accordance with the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution hereby resolve to ratify the said Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the West Cape Three

Point Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Amendment for the Extension of Terms of Deepwater Tano Petroleum between GoG, GNPC, Tullow Ghana Ltd, Kosmos Energy Ghana and PetroSA Ghana Ltd

Mr J. A. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

WHEREAS

1. By the provisions of Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, any transaction, contract or undertaking involving the grant of a right or concession by or on behalf of any person or body of persons howsoever described, for the exploitation of any mineral, water or other natural resource of Ghana made or entered into after the coming into force of the Constitution is made subject to ratification by Parliament;

2. In pursuance of the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution, the Government of Ghana has caused to be laid before Parliament through the Minister responsible for Energy and Green Transition, the Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

NOW THEREFORE, this House in accordance with the said Article 268 (1) of the Constitution hereby resolve to ratify the said Amendment for the extension of the Terms of the Deepwater Tano Petroleum Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation, GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company, Tullow Ghana Limited, Kosmos Energy Ghana HC, Kosmos Energy Ghana Investments and PetroSA Ghana Limited.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Resolution.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, on an important occasion like this, where a Resolution is to be moved which carries the force of law, I would want to draw the attention of the House to the need to comply with constitutional requirements, which means that we should have the sufficient numbers to proceed. Mr Speaker, I would want to draw the attention of the Chair to facilitate this being done.

That said, let me also place on record that earlier I could not catch your eye. The Minority, through its Ranking Member had indicated to Leadership that the report that was moved by the Chair had certain views that were to be captured by the Minority Side of the House. In spite of insistence according to the Ranking Member, this was not done. Mr Speaker, I believe that when we all attend Committee meetings and build consensus on a matter and express divergent views, it is important that said views are properly captured in the Report to reflect opinions. The disagreement may be mild, but these views must be captured.

Mr Speaker, I sit here as a Leader of the Minority Side, and if my Ranking Member comes to report to Leadership that in spite of insistence this was not allowed, it is part of our democracy to allow views to be expressed. So, I was on my feet to draw attention to this important matter because I know that whatever we are doing here has effect

outside. That opportunity, we could not get, and I do not blame you, Mr Speaker, because when you put the question, I could not catch your eye. But having caught your eye, I feel that it is important I bring this to your attention. Mr Speaker, without more, I would want to rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, but sometimes it is not good to create the impression that we are not fair. Your Ranking Member did very well. He placed all matters on record, and everybody in the Chamber can attest to that fact that the Ranking Member did very well. Hon Okyere Darko-Mensah, picked it up and also spoke very well. If you were watching me, I was nodding my head. When even the Ranking Member finished speaking, I indicated “thank you for your observations”. Hon Boamah-Nyarko was also given the opportunity when I called on the leadership of the Minority, as the Leadership of the Minority yielded to him to speak. So, for me, once that has been done, it is the turn of the Majority. So, clearly, I was no longer looking at the direction of the Minority.

So, when issues are debated, and your Backbench did very well on placing matters on record, I think we have put a question onto the Motion and the Motion has been adopted by the House, we cannot go back and revisit the debate on the Motion.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not talking about a debate. I am not asking us to go and debate the

issue. Let us put matters in proper context.

Mr Speaker, my issue is that my Ranking Member had insisted on having the views captured. There is a difference between a debate on the Floor and the report as captured for *Hansard*. Our contention is simply that those views that were supposed to be captured in the report were not. Mr Speaker, I am speaking on behalf of my Side.

4:20 p.m.

It is what the Ranking Member has insisted that he was denying, that I am putting across on our behalf, that the Report was supposed to have captured key concerns, and it was not done. Mr Speaker, please permit me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I will permit you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Yesterday, he made the effort to get the Report amended. In fact, according to him, when the Report was done, the draft Report was not sent to him. For his Side, he and his Deputy Ranking Member were with me, and they said they were waiting for the final draft. Normally, the practice is that when the draft is ready, he would get a copy, go through it, and ensure that whatever they have discussed has been captured. But by the time he got wind of it, the Report had already been signed. So, when he came to me, I said he should engage the Chairperson so that the Report could be amended. He told me

that he insisted, tried as he could, but he did not get the opportunity to get the Report amended.

Mr Speaker, there is a difference between his argument that is made on the Floor and the views of the Minority captured in the Report.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The problem that I have is that the very Ranking Member that you are speaking for was given the opportunity to speak to the Report, and he spoke to the Report. All that you are saying is a matter that should have been taken into consideration at the time the Report is being taken. Now, we have passed through the stage of adopting the Report and the Motion. We are now on consequential Resolutions, and you are raising an issue about the Report.

Your Ranking Member has clearly been given the opportunity to speak, and he did so until he concluded. So, what are we doing to ourselves to create a wrong impression? He had the opportunity to speak. If your Ranking Member were not to be here, or were not to be given the opportunity to speak, it would be worth listening to or taking the point you are making. It appears we are trying to cry louder than the bereaved. We want to be more holy than the Pope.

So, in the circumstances, let us take the Resolution numbered 19.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not comfortable with the metaphor that concluded your comment. Mr Speaker, with respect, I lead a Side

and act on the instructions of my Side. There is nothing like somebody crying more than the belief. I understand the metaphor; I understand language. This is our Side, so do not say somebody is happy – and no, we will not take this issue of somebody using language to divide our Side. We have a position. This thing must end.

Mr Speaker, we will show respect, but the same thing must be extended to us. I was somewhere; I had to rush in to resolve this matter for my Side. So please. I raise an issue to draw Mr Speaker's attention to the fact that this is what I have been told. Mr Speaker had already called for the Question to be put. Mr Speaker did not see me, but I am not questioning him. I know how the House can act sometimes. But I have taken it easy, and there is always a tomorrow. If the Minister for Energy and Green Transition thinks today, he slipped through, so be it. Be smart on it.

But, Mr Speaker, he does not have the numbers to rush these Resolutions. And if he does not want it to be pursued, his posture— *[Uproar]*

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we would take the first two Statements.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Which of the Statements are we taking?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Statement on the hospital, the lack of emergency support for the—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You brought the Statement to my office today. I have accepted the Statement and indicated to you that I will read through, admit it, and transmit same to the Clerk to Parliament for onward transmission to the House to be taken. Hon Members, with all due respect, if the Statement is not transmitted to the Clerk, it may not even be uploaded on the console for copies to be available for Hon Members to read. So, with all due respect.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: I have seen the Statement on the attack on tomato sellers in Burkina Faso. We will deal with that one.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: My simple question is; which Statement are we taking?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The Statement on the attack on tomato sellers in Burkina Faso.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, in your absence, your Whip raised a very germane point. I sat in the Chamber. I listened carefully to the Whip. The Whip complained that some Statements have been on the *Order Paper* to be taken, and those Statements are not being taken. The impression is being created as if some Statements are more important than others. So, those who were in the House at that particular time listened carefully to the Whip.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let us take a Statement. Minority Leader, can we take your Statement, if Mr Speaker grants permission?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I do not know. Let us open the actual Statement on the console because regarding that Statement, I have written to the Clerk. So, let us open the Statement on the console. So long as I am concerned, I have not admitted that Statement. So which Statement is on the console, Clerks-at-the-Table?

Ms Patricia Appiagyei: No, this Statement is on the horrific killing of the seven Ghanaians, the tomato—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I am told that is not the Statement on the console. What the Minority Leader is talking about is not on the console.

4:30 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, early on, the Clerk to Parliament had approached me and indicated that a Statement relating to the killings in Burkina Faso had been presented to you. You had requested that the Statement be edited and the Statement was therefore edited and reduced.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That Statement that I have edited stands in the name of Hon Okyere Baafi, not the Hon Minority Leader.

Hon Members, I can share with you what happened. While I was editing the Statement on this subject matter submitted by Hon Okyere Baafi, Hon Ntim Fordjour brought a five-page Statement on the same subject matter. I was by then seated beside the Second

Deputy Speaker. So, I told him, to the hearing of the Second Deputy Speaker, that I do not admit Statements on the floor of the House and that the Statement should be sent to my Office. He can bear witness. The Second Deputy Speaker can also bear witness. Then the Clerk to Parliament brought the said Statement back and cursory look at it indicated that it was on the same subject matter.

So, I said, Statements are supposed to be transmitted through the Whips. If these two Statements were transmitted through the Whip, they would have realised that the two Statements are on the same subject matter so, one person should reduce his to a comment, because they are from the same Side. However, the Statement was also too long, five pages and we have one hour for Statement. So, I was unable to admit the Statement. That was my minute to the Clerk to Parliament. This morning, same Statement was brought by the Hon Minority Leader, this time round, in the names of the two Members.

So, I indicated clearly to the Clerk to Parliament that a similar Statement has been submitted to me and that I have already considered from same Side, same subject matter, a Statement in the name of Hon Michael Okyere Baafi, so the Member may comment when Hon Baafi's Statement is taken. So, I am surprised that they will say that Statement has been admitted and has to be taken.

Hon Members, no one judges a swimmer by the certificate on the shore. He should tell us the number of pages of the Statement that he currently has.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, since the Statement by Hon Baafi, which you have admitted, is on the same subject matter, Hon Baafi is engaged in some work outside the Chamber and I have had discussions with him for Hon Asafo-Adjei to make that Statement on his behalf, by your leave. So, we go by your earlier suggestion that we take only one Statement, then the comments can capture all the issues because it is on the same subject matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But it must be a Statement that I have admitted and transmitted to the Clerk to Parliament. Why am I saying this? When you are reading a Statement admitted, I or whoever is presiding has a copy to ensure that what has been admitted is what you are reading. So, I have a difficulty when the Statement is not admitted. And what you have is a five-page Statement that I have declined admission.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: It appears you are not listening to this Side. I am saying that let us make progress. The Statement by Hon Baafi, which you have admitted—Or that one too, you have not admitted?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, as for the Statement by Hon Baafi, I have admitted it.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you have made up your mind on something. Please listen to the suggestion that is coming from this Side. With respect, Mr Speaker, I am saying that the Statement by Hon Baafi, which

you have admitted, we are ready to take it. He is engaged in some parliamentary work outside of the Chamber and in the discussion with him, he worked on the Statement with Hon Asafo-Adjei. He is here to take it. Then we go by your earlier suggestions where Members can make comments on the Statement so that there would be no need for Hon Ntim Fordjour to still pursue another Statement which is on the same subject matter; he can comment on—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, sometimes we do not know it all. Statements, unlike Questions, can they be taken by a Member on behalf of another Member?

Well, I just want to be guided.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, invoke the rule of prudence. We are Members of Parliament. We are Colleagues and this is a national issue. So, I am pleading with you, Mr Speaker, to invoke the rule of prudence and let Hon Asafo-Adjei do it on his behalf.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, since you have gone through that Statement and in principle admitted it, even though the author of the Statement is not available, I believe we can appeal to you to relax the rules and allow somebody else to read the Statement on behalf of the author.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. If that is the sense of the House.

Yes, Hon Alhassan Suhuyini?

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan:
Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, this may seem inconsequential, but I think that it is important that we establish protocols regarding how Statements or Bills that are supposed to be published on the console are done. Today, we may be discussing a matter that does not invoke much passion and so it may be considered light.

Mr Speaker, listening to you and reading the Statement that is on the console, you are absolutely right. What is on the console actually is about six pages. And on the console, we can clearly see your note to the Clerk to Parliament, which actually says that the Statement is too long. Mr Speaker, your written note is here: “The statement is too long. It should be edited to fit”.

So as to how this got onto the console, Mr Speaker, should be a matter of concern. **[An Hon Member: Mysteriously]** Exactly. Mysteriously got onto the console, should be a matter of concern. It should perhaps give us an indication that there is a need for us to establish protocols as to how things get onto the console. Otherwise, one day, something more controversial can get onto the console and we may spend the whole day unable to resolve it.

So, Mr Speaker, I thought I should draw your attention to this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, the question boils down to a Statement that was not admitted, a Statement that was

declined. How did it get onto the console? That is simply, the matter.

4:40 p.m.

Hon Members, we need to be very careful. Certain matters can become a subject matter of privileges. We need to be extremely careful.

So, in the meantime, as they are doing the finding, can we take any advertised Statement?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I think we have settled this matter that Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh takes the admitted Statement on behalf of Hon Baafi. That is what we have agreed upon and he is ready to take it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Who else has a copy of the Statement? I have modified it, so let me see the modified one.

We may go ahead to take the Statement standing in the name of Mr Michael Baafi Okyere. I modified the Statement so if I do not have the modified Statement, how would I be able to know that that is what he is reading?

Let us take five minutes' suspension. I would like to see the Leaders at the Conclave.

4:43 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

5:27 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we got to a point where we agreed that the Statement standing in the

name of Hon Okyere Baafi should be taken on his behalf by Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh. So, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Asafo-Adjei Ayeh.

STATEMENTS

Terrorist Attack on Ghanaian Tomato Traders in Titao, Burkina Faso

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh *on behalf of Hon Micheal Baafi Okyere (NPP — New Juaben South)*: Mr Speaker, I rise to address a matter of grave national concern, the brutal terrorist attack in Titao, in the northern Burkina Faso, which has claimed the lives of seven Ghanaian tomato traders and left several others injured.

Mr Speaker, according to confirmed reports by the Minister for the Interior, a truck carrying 10 men and eight women was caught in an assault on February 14th. The attackers reportedly separated the men from the women and shot the men on sight. Seven men were killed, the three others sustained serious injuries, one woman suffered serious injuries, while seven women escaped without severe physical harm.

Mr Speaker, these were not combatants; they were traders, breadwinners, husbands, fathers and sons. Many of them were informed here from Koforidua in my beloved constituency. Today, families in my region and across Ghana are grieving. I extend my deepest condolences to the bereaved families and pray for strength and comfort them in this painful hour.

May the souls of the departed compatriots rest in perfect peace.

Mr Speaker, this is not simply an unfortunate incident. When a neighbouring state is engulfed in insurgency, and it is part of a regional realignment away from the ECOWAS structures, including the ECOWAS Trade Liberalisation Scheme, which facilitates cross-border trade, prudence demands heightened vigilance from our government. This Government cannot hide behind the rhetoric of regional cooperation. While the Minister has pointed out a recent security summit in Accra, summits alone do not protect citizens. Intelligence, coordination, actionable advisories and structured risk mitigation mechanisms do.

Mr Speaker, our tomato traders form an essential backbone of Ghanaian agriculture value chain and cross-border commerce. Yet they were left exposed in a volatile theatre of insurgency without adequate security protection or warning. That, Mr Speaker, is a failure of governance. This House, the Minority, demands the following: an immediate parliamentary enquiry into the circumstances surrounding this tragedy, including whether prior intelligence warning existed, and what steps, if any, were taken to protect Ghanaian traders operating in high-risk zones.

Two, full compensation and State support for the families of the diseased and the injured. These families must not bear the burden alone. Three: a comprehensive review of Ghana's regional security protocol, including

travel advisories, cross-border trade risk assessments, and diplomatic coordination with state-experienced armed insurgencies. Four: a briefing to Parliament from the Minister of the Interior, Minister of Finance, Defence and National Security on the evolving security architecture within the Sahel region and its implications for Ghanaian citizens.

Mr Speaker, the loss of lives represents a painful reminder that regional instability is no longer distinct. It is immediate. It is a deadly thing. The Ghanaian people deserve a government that anticipates threats, not one that reacts after tragedy strikes. We owe it to the victims to ensure that never again are our citizens subjected to these cruel actions or these cruel acts without the full protection and vigilance of the Republic.

I thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the urgent Statement is now for comment. Yes, looking at your back, I will give the floor to Hon Atta-Mills before coming to you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by way of a guide, can we take two on each Side? [*Uproar*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is not the first time that the Leadership of the House has engaged on the number of contributions we should take. This may not be the last. So, if Leadership is engaging in the number of contributions we should take, I think this

is what we have always been doing as a House.

Hon Members, the earlier indication is that we have 19 other Statements. If we add this one, the total is 20 Statements. Look at the *Order Paper*. Is there any other Statement captured on the *Order Paper* that is not important?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the proposal is that we take three on each Side including the Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let me hear from the Minority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we proposed six on each Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, can we have some order? At least the Leader is on his feet.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we proposed six on each Side because of the nature of the situation, and our Hon Colleagues are calling for three. So, I think we can have a consensus on five each and make some progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kwame Agbodza?

Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I think this is a very important Statement. Let us do 25, 25 on each Side so that we can have enough time to speak.

5:37 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, by way of providing a guide, I

think we can do four on each Side including Leadership.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, with the earlier Statement, we took two on each Side plus the Leadership, making three. It is only fair.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. But in the circumstances, we would take three from each Side plus Leadership, making four. I plead with Hon Members that we go strictly by the rules. When a Member gets up to speak, I will indicate the time, and please, when your time is up, do the honourable thing. I do not want a situation where your time will be up, but you ignore the Chair, particularly the Mace, and continue talking when the indication is that your time is up. I will also signal you when you have one more minute left.

So, the floor is now open for comment.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, just for the record, for our Side, the three are Hon Ntim Fordjour, Hon Dominic Nitiwul, and Hon Abu Jinapor, then we come to Leadership.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we are going by the usual five minutes as stated by the rules, that comments must not exceed five minutes.

Hon Members, we will start with Hon Ntim Fordjour. The time is 5:40 p.m., so you are stopping at 5:45 p.m.

You have the floor.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, this is a Statement made by this Side, so their Side has spoken. If you say four on both Sides, then that becomes five from their Side and four on our Side.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you know that in terms of these numbers, you do not include the Maker of the Statement.

You have the floor. It is now 5:41 p.m., so you would end at 5:46 p.m.

Rev John Ntim Fordjour (NPP — Assin North): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I rise to first express condolences to the eight persons who were killed in the horrific terrorist killings in Burkina Faso. Ghanaian traders, breadwinners, pillars of their families, contributors to society and our prayers are with those who are injured and receiving treatment. My condolences to the family.

Mr Speaker, it is a very sad day, 14th February, a day that should have been a day of joy, a day of love, celebrating Valentine and Chocolate Day, rather became a sad day for this country where the only crime our 19 compatriots committed was to go about their legitimate business, going for goods so that households may eat in this country. But for the failure of the Government and the State to protect these citizens even beyond our borders, for security failure, they met their untimely death.

Mr Speaker, I would want to first point out the security failure on the part of the State, because these deaths and

these killings are avoidable. The geopolitics of the sub-region is public knowledge. The terrorism threats and crisis we have within our neighbouring countries, especially Burkina Faso, is one that is not in doubt and one that did not start yesterday. For the failure of the State to even provide travel advisory ahead of time, to advise travellers to Burkina Faso and to identify the high-risk areas, and for these traders to be led into the slaughter is most regrettable and most barbaric.

Mr Speaker, were there any effective joint intelligence sharing? And what intelligence was picked up by the people whose job it is to ensure that these intelligences are picked up and Ghanaians travelling to these hot zones are warned ahead of time? What safe passage arrangements were put in place to ensure that Ghanaians travelling to these hotspots were accompanied if indeed they had to go and return?

Mr Speaker, we demand answers. A lot has to be answered. What corridor threat mapping was conducted and what enhanced security and safe passage mechanisms were activated in these places, knowing very well the situation and the threats we have in this country? And it comes at a time where for seven months we have no substantive Minister for Defence who will lead these bilateral arrangements to ensure that these adequate security arrangements are put in place to protect our citizens who travel to Burkina Faso.

Mr Speaker, I would again want to point out another failure on the part of

the Government. Even when the crisis occurred, the Government failed to offer a coordinated government response. It has been six days since the incident occurred, and yet the Minister for Defence and the Minister for Foreign Affairs have all failed even to make a trip to Burkina Faso to engage at the high level to ensure that the circumstances are ascertained and measures are put in place to forestall this unfortunate happening.

Mr Speaker, another failure I wish to point out was the failure on the part of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Ministry of Defence even to activate timeous consular response. As we speak, the bodies of our compatriots who perished have not been in a dignified manner identified. There is no dignified repatriation of their bodies. Even before the Ghanaian authorities would get there, belatedly, the bodies had been buried. So, we are denying their families the opportunity to have a dignified burial for these people.

Mr Speaker, when the El-Wak Stadium incident occurred and six people were killed, immediately that same day, an Urgent Statement was admitted, the Minister for Defence came here and briefed the House. It has been six days now and no Minister for Defence or Minister for Foreign Affairs, has had the courtesy to even appear before this House to brief the House. This goes to show the negligence on the part of the State and those whose responsibilities it is to protect our citizens.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Rev Fordjour: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I would give the floor to Hon Kwame Govers Agbodza.

You time is 5:46 p.m.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza): Mr Speaker, I join my Colleague, who just spoke, to extend our condolences to our compatriots who died in this horrific situation. We pray that those who are injured, and we are aware that many of them have recovered, and those who are still recovering, we wish them a speedy recovery.

Mr Speaker, the Statement is supposed to be a very solemn one, and to unite us to make sure that we do the right thing. But, when my Colleague was speaking, he spoke about many things that I would give him the benefit of the doubt, because he is probably not aware of what actually took place. He made the statement; “They were led to the slaughter.” Mr Speaker, no Ghanaian was led to the slaughter. My Colleague is a Reverend Minister, and knows very well that nobody was led to the slaughter.

Mr Speaker, he also sought to denigrate the very diplomatic and very hard-working staff of our country in Burkina Faso. For his information, in fact, they have been praised for the

timeous and helpful activities they did. They were actually there and did everything possible to give support to our people. So, the statement he made that there was nothing like that is completely false as a matter of fact.

Mr Speaker, indeed, Ghanaians are all over the world. Today, it may sound very politically convenient for him to say that even if one person died in that situation, it is a very horrific situation that must be dealt with.

5:47 p.m.

But we were in this country when 44 of our compatriots were killed in 2005 in Gambia, and we were expecting President Kufuor to ensure that those 44 people had people escorting them around Gambia. Let us separate politics from some of the realities. What happened was wrong. It is a terrorist situation, and I know from the briefing I had that our country did whatever they could. We are still working with people to make sure that the rest of the people in Burkina Faso are protected.

Mr Speaker, I just want to say that some of the things that happen in our country cannot be political. I want to caution all our Hon Colleagues that while it may sound—And the use of words like “they should have been escorted” or “they should have been given travel advice”—Mr Speaker, when we travel even into countries that we call safe—How many of us here entered United Kingdom or United States of America and reported to our Mission that we are in those countries? We do not do

it. Show us evidence that when you travel— Mr Speaker, it is easy. We travel across the globe. How many times did we report to the Mission?

Mr Speaker, yes, our compatriots went to Burkina Faso to trade in tomatoes and other things. Unfortunately, the problem between Mali and Burkina Faso, the area where the thing happened, was clearly an isolated place that terrorists have operated before. It is not as if it is something that has happened which is the fault of anybody. I was going to tell my Colleague that, please, families are still grieving. Families are still trying to nurse injured members. So, let us be very careful the way we speak about these things. I am waiting to hear how the former Minister for Defence would have handled that in the past. In fact, the Hon Member said that it is because we do not have a substantive Minister. Under former President Kufuor, we had a substantive Minister, yet 44 of our compatriots were murdered in Gambia. It is not about whether we have Ministers or not. So, let us be guided. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I take the opportunity again to wish the families of the deceased our condolences and pray that those who are injured recover fully. We need to strengthen the ties between our neighbours, Burkina Faso and others to make sure that we work against terrorists wherever they operate. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give the floor to Hon Samuel Abdulai

Jinapor. The time is 5:50 p.m. and the Hon Member will stop at 5:55 p.m.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Mr Speaker, let me join my Hon Colleagues to express our condolences to the family. And very quickly, I want to throw light on what the Minister for Roads and Highways has just said. Mr Speaker, countries across the world give travel advice. The United Kingdom does it, the United States of America does it. In fact, our Government, President Mahama's Government, after this incident in Burkina Faso, has issued a travel advice. It is very normal for Governments to issue travel advice.

Mr Speaker, what happened in Gambia was unfortunate. Indeed, this is the second time Ghanaians have been murdered in such circumstances outside the shores of our country. Mr Speaker, but it has to be distinguished. This is a terrorist attack. What happened in Gambia was not a terrorist attack. That is why leading security experts, such as Dr Kwasi Annin, Emmanuel Bombande, Vladimir Antwi-Danso, have indicated that what happened in Burkina Faso should be a huge wake-up call to the Ghanaian national security apparatus. We should not belittle this matter. This House should pay particular attention to what has happened in Burkina Faso. This is a major security breach. On a daily basis, our compatriots travel to Burkina Faso, Togo and La Cote d'Ivoire. It is their daily existence. Therefore, if tomato sellers, marketers, and traders have been murdered, tomorrow it could be students. The day after tomorrow, it

could be another group of Ghanaians. Mr Speaker, across the divide, we should agree that the demands the Minority have made, that we should have a bipartisan enquiry into this matter, should not be belittled. This is a major wake-up call to the national security apparatus of our country.

Mr Speaker, what would the former Minister for Defence, Hon Dominic Nitiwul, have done differently if he had the opportunity? I want to indicate to my Friend, the Minister for Roads and Highways, that what the former Minister for Defence would have done is exactly what he did when President Nana Akufo-Addo was in office, the Accra Initiative. The Accra Initiative was a major initiative by the Nana Akufo-Addo's Administration, which brought countries along the coasts, Ghana, Togo, Benin, and Nigeria, and which co-opted Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger. In all modesty, as Deputy Chief of Staff and Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, when I had the privilege to sit in the National Security Council, I saw at first hand the work the Accra Initiative did, which ensured that we had sharing of intelligence, which ensured that we collaborated with our neighbours, which ensured that we had robust mechanisms to prevent, to pre-empt, to protect, and to respond. That is why for eight years, not even one soul of our compatriots was lost in Burkina Faso.

Mr Speaker, the second thing that the Akufo-Addo Government would have done, and the Minister asked that question, is that, we will not align in the conflict in Burkina Faso. We will

continue to be leaders in the ECOWAS, and we will continue to support legitimate governments across the West African region. But we will be careful not to portray our Government in a manner which will make our citizens targets. Mr Speaker, security experts indicated that immediately the President of Burkina Faso, General Ibrahim Traoré, became a special guest at the inauguration of President Mahama—I am not saying it, security experts indicated that Ghanaians were going to become targets. Indeed, let us ask ourselves the fundamental question. These traders are not combatants, these traders do not play any role in the conflict in Burkina Faso, these traders do not pose any threat, so why were they attacked? Mr Speaker, I think our Friends on the other Side should agree with us for us to have this bipartisan enquiry, to assemble the facts, and to have the situation unraveled in a bipartisan and objective manner.

Mr Speaker, I want to indicate that the allegation or suspicion other security experts have posited that it is because Ghana is seen to be aligning with the Government of Burkina Faso, our citizens have become targets, let us establish that allegation to be true or not. I am not insisting that it is true, but we need to find out the truth.

Mr Speaker, I conclude by indicating that this is beyond politics. This is beyond NPP and NDC. We have never had this before. This is unprecedented. This is a major wake-up call to the security architecture of our country and to the Parliament of Ghana. Therefore,

let us set up this bipartisan committee of enquiry. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Atta-Mills, you have the floor. Your time is 5:55 p.m., so you would stop exactly at 6 o'clock.

Mr Samuel Atta-Mills (NDC — Komenda/Edina/Eguafo/Abrem):

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I know this is a very sad thing that has happened to our members in Burkina Faso, but just to answer some of the questions over there. The killings are avoidable. The killings are avoidable. But let me remind you of something. Their former flagbearer, who is now their new flagbearer, went on television and said the best thing he has ever done in the north was the Pwalugu Dam. This Pwalugu Dam was supposed to help us irrigate the land. Look, what happened was that we spent US\$12 million and we do not have anything to show. If this Dam has been built, we would have been able to grow our tomatoes up north. Ghanaians would not have to go to Burkina Faso. They spent that.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin — rose —

Mr Atta-Mills: Do you know what we need to do? Let us find out who “chopped” that US\$12 million.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Atta-Mills, you have done one minute.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, if we use this platform to open— can I finish?
[Uproar]

Mr Speaker, this is a statement that deals with matters specifically mentioned in the Statement.

5:57 p.m.

Mr Speaker, if Hon Atta-Mills, enjoying that privilege as a Member of the House, uses that privilege to attack our flag-bearer and quote —[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order!

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I would want to invite the Chair to order that aspect of the submissions that sought to quote the flag-bearer of the New Patriotic Party (NPP), and to attribute comments unrelated to the subject matter in issue and secondly, to impugn improper motive.

Mr Speaker, time and again, even in admitting Statements, you have had cause to caution and even to edit situations where H.E. the President's name has come under reference in a Statement and this Side has respected that. They are our leaders. Let us be fair, because as soon as that Pandora's box is allowed to be opened — [Interruption] Mr Speaker, Hon Atta-Mills is a respected gentleman and we all know him to be so in this House. I have called him ‘Uncle’ since he entered this Chamber. Considering his own stock, he belongs to a stock of gentlemen and measured language. Hon Atta-Mills knows that it is wrong for him to impugn improper motive on a matter that

is not before the House, against a person who is a leader of our party and is not part of this House.

Mr Speaker, I repeat one more time and without more, the Pandora's box must be closed. If this humble advice is not taken and the Pandora's box is to be opened, I leave it to those who have opened it.

Mr Nitiwul — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, why are you up? Hon Atta-Mills, take the concern raised by the Minority Leader into account and whatever you say must be limited to the tomato trade that has taken them outside the country, resulting into the incidents.

Mr Atta-Mills: It is a sad situation. But what I am saying is this, Mr Speaker, if a person is a driver and has bad wheels, then the person gets to the end and gets into an accident, do we blame it on the potholes? We need to be careful the way we run our politics here in town. We always want to blame somebody else without looking at what we should have done earlier.

The reason I brought out this Pwalugu Multipurpose Dam was to help us with our tomato industry. There were so many things that we should have done. Now we are talking about—
[Uproar]

Some Hon Members of the Minority — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Order! Hon Members, kindly resume your

seats. Hon Atta-Mills, kindly move away from that.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I just read a newspaper article and a news publication in which market women in Techiman are demanding that we irrigate their land, so that they do not have to travel to Burkina Faso to buy tomatoes. It is there; they should go online. I just read it. Under the Pwalugu Multipurpose Dam Project, we were to irrigate 25,000 hectares of land; that is 61,000 acres of land. One acre yields three metric tonnes of tomatoes. So, if we had cultivated 61,000 acres of land, we would have been producing 185,000 metric tonnes of tomatoes. Mr Speaker, if the Pwalugu Multipurpose Dam had been constructed, the women would not be going to Burkina Faso. This is a question of fact. He is talking about us not doing enough to protect our citizens. This is how we protect our citizens: irrigate their lands. When we take US\$12 million to do irrigation for them, we should do the irrigation. We should not “chop” the money. They “chopped” the money, drove the women into Burkina Faso to buy tomatoes and they went and died there now, they want to do politics in this Chamber.

Mr Speaker, it is legitimate for anyone on our Side to discuss the multipurpose dam at Pwalugu. This is because the whole idea behind the multipurpose dam was to irrigate so that we produce the tomatoes in Ghana. That is why we have the Pwalugu Tomato

factory. So, it is perfectly legitimate for us to raise the issue of the multipurpose dam. Why are they running away from that?

6:07 p.m.

They are eager to jump and talk about women being killed in Burkina Faso. But they do not want us to discuss what has led them into Burkina Faso. And they said that this Government led the women into Burkina Faso. It is not this Government. It is the tomato factory that they did not allow to be constructed. It is the multi-purpose dam; it is the US\$12 million they “*chopped*”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, with all due respect, if you can bear with me, you will realise that the Majority Chief Whip was on his feet several times when Hon John Ntim Fordjour was speaking. I refused to recognise him when I could hear objectionable issues. So, Hon Members, let us accommodate one another. Let us all be guided by the Standing Orders that you are entitled to comment on the Statement, but the Statement should not generate a debate. What you are saying is true, but the way you put it will generate a debate.

Hon Members, I indicated that the Statement has diplomatic implications. So, let us all be guided in the way we use our five minutes to comment on the Statement. Again, I will urge the Hon Member to move away from that. He would have three more minutes to conclude his comments.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, before Hon Atta-Mills gets the opportunity to continue with his comment, the Majority Leader has made certain statements which have gone into the *Hansard*? Mr Speaker, the allegation that somebody has “*chopped*” US\$12 million, I challenge him — the Hon Member, who is the Majority Leader, is a lawyer, and he knows. I challenge him to come out with any evidence to point to a person who has abused any so-called money.

Mr Speaker, his party is in Government, where is the 24-Hour Economy, and where is the one job: three shifts? This is their second year in office, what jobs have they created? There is an issue; deal with it! They are talking about a tomato factory, which they have been in office for one year. This is their second year. So why are they — before this administration, they were in office for eight years, so what are they talking about? They should not throw dust into the eyes of people.

They are a Government of blame game; always interested in the optics, and full of comments. Less work; more talk. We want evidence of their hard work. They should show us the tangibles of their one year in office. They are promoting *galamsey*. Cocoa prices and farm gate prices are coming down. They are not even ashamed to reduce cocoa prices. They do not care about the poor farmers, and they are not even ashamed. Then they come here and want to put our flagbearer on a chopping board.

Mr Speaker, if the Majority Leader wants to debate, then he should prepare because we have all the facts to challenge him. They cannot create jobs; they are denying cocoa farmers their money. The farmers have earned their money, but they are not paying them, and they are not even ashamed of it. Indeed, Pwalugu goes against them.

[Some Hon Members from the Majority chant, "Pwalugu".]

They should keep singing it. If they create jobs in Pwalugu, it will help the poor in that part of the Region. They should keep on. If they think anybody has "chopped" any money, they should prosecute the person. If they think they have evidence, they should go to court. People have died under their watch, and they are denying cocoa farmers their legitimate earnings. So, they should go and create jobs at Pwalugu. It is good that they are singing Pwalugu; they should create jobs in Pwalugu. They should go ahead.

Mr Speaker, they will not get away with their incompetence and inaction. They have a Government; it is their duty to deliver on their promises. That is their duty as a Government. Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think if we can all stick to the rules, the better it is for everybody. The rules are made to guide us. Your comment on the Statement should not generate into debates. We agreed on the number of people who will be speaking. If you go this way, we may have to spend

the rest of the evening on one Statement. Hon Samuel Atta-Mills, you have the floor, but please sheer away from that.

Mr Atta-Mills: Mr Speaker, I will stay away from the "d" word. But what I am saying is, as Ghanaians, we should not be going outside to buy simple things like tomatoes. We need to grow our own tomatoes. And we need to find ways to make sure that we grow our own tomatoes. I just wanted to sound a word of caution; be careful how we blame the other side. Sometimes, we have to look at ourselves first and ask: What could I have done? We need to be careful with the way that we blame others. These were Ghanaians who went there. Maybe what we need to do is, if the one district one dam had worked —*[Laughter]*, maybe we could have had more farmers up north.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Nitiwul.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, in the history of Ghana, this is the most devastating terrorist attack where at least eight of our citizens have lost their lives. Some reports say nine, but at least eight have been confirmed.

Mr Speaker, I will not be tempted to downplay the severity of this situation. I will not be tempted because we have grieving families. If they are watching what is happening in Parliament today, they will be very sad that their

representatives can be singing and we are laughing when people have lost their lives. Maybe we do not see the effect of what has happened in Burkina Faso.

Mr Speaker, we may not see it today, but I can tell you that, after sitting there for eight years, it is a very serious thing and Ghanaians will have to take it up.

6:17 p.m.

Yes, anybody from the north, including all of us from the north, will say that the greatest thing that will happen to the north, especially those in Upper East, Upper West and North East Regions, would be the construction of the Pwalugu Dam. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) has been given 17 years in power, and the New Patriotic Party (NPP), 16 years in power. The cost of the Pwalugu Dam—So anybody, after 16 years, who now dreamt that we must have a Pwalugu Dam should be praised. They should praise Dr Bawumia for bringing up that concept. *[Uproar]* Mr Speaker, the cost of that project was US\$993 million, and a mobilisation of US\$11.9 million was paid. Mr Speaker, if they think that paying mobilisation was a crime, they should convict the people. They are in Government for 14 months. What are they doing? And they are still complaining as if they are in opposition.

But Mr Speaker, like I said, I want to talk about security matters. For the first time in our history—Terrorism started in Burkina Faso in 2018. And you can ask the Association of Tomato Sellers, the main reason these people went there is because they had the illusion that

Ghanaians would never be attacked. You can go outside and ask the president of the Association of Tomato Sellers. They had the illusion that as for Ghanaians—In fact, their interpreter told them that as for Ghanaians, they do not attack them, and that they can go. It has always been so. Why is it that they attacked them? The vehicle was a Ghanaian vehicle, and they knew the registration number was Ghanaian. The language they spoke to them—They had to speak to them through an interpreter, so they knew they were Ghanaians. Why were they attacked? That is what we should be asking ourselves. For eight years, in fact, for 10 years, since 2018 till now, they never attacked Ghanaians. Why is it that for the first time they have attacked Ghanaians?

Mr Speaker, that is why I said that we should not downplay it. It is a very serious matter. We should not downplay it.

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, you have two more minutes. Let me listen to the Hon Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, unfortunately, the former Minister for Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, Hon Shirley Ayorkor Botchway, is no longer with us here. In 2023, nine of my constituents crossed over into Burkina Faso because they had kept their cattle with some Fulani headsmen there, and the military rounded the cattle up. And when they announced that they should come for their cattle, and my constituents crossed

over to collect their cattle, nine of them were killed. I reported to the then Minister for Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration in 2023. The Minister tried to reach out to her counterpart. Up to date, we have not even been able to retrieve their bodies.

[Some Hon Members chanted.]

So, Mr Speaker, Hon Nitiwul cannot say that this is the first time that Ghanaians have been attacked in Burkina Faso. Many Ghanaians have been attacked and killed in Burkina Faso. Indeed, let me tell you one thing. At a certain point— *[Uproar]* My constituency shares border with Burkina Faso, so I am telling you from personal knowledge.

Let me tell you how it started. When the terrorists started their fights, because we introduced free medical care through the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) —*[Uproar]*. A lot of Burkinabes crossed over to our side of the border, got our national identification card, and then used it to register onto the NHIS, so that anytime they were sick, they would cross over and attend our hospitals. What happened? When the conflict started, anytime that the terrorists killed some young people, very often when they checked their pockets, they found a Ghanaian national identification card. So, they began to think that Ghanaians were crossing over to join the government against the terrorists. That was when they started attacking Ghanaians.

I share border with Burkina Faso. Whatever happens there, I get to know. So, you cannot say this is the first time that Ghanaians have been killed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, you still have your two minutes intact. It is now 6:24 p.m.; you will stop at 6:26 p.m.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, is it not sad that the Hon Majority Leader would inform Ghanaians that nine of his people were killed by Burkina Faso military, and he never made a Statement in this House? *[Interruption]* That is what he is saying. And his people are here shouting “Pwalugu”. He did not make a Statement in this House on it. It is very sad.

Mr Speaker, I say that the reason they are targeting Ghanaians is exactly what the Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor said. The perception that we are aligning with the Burkina Faso authority is making us enemies of the people, the terrorists. And in any case, the nine people who died were killed by Burkina Faso military, as he said, not by the terrorists. So, it was not a terrorist attack. And they are singing “Pwalugu” here. His people died, we are talking about it, and they are singing “Pwalugu”. Look for the 900 million —*[Uproar]*

Mr Speaker, secondly, why is the Minister for Foreign Affairs now issuing travel advisories instead of before? Thirdly, where is the Minister for Defence? Why is the Minister for Defence of Ghana not on a flight to Burkina Faso? Unfortunately, it is not the duty of the Minister for the Interior.

That is not his duty. His duty ends at Paga border. It is the Minister for Defence. The soldiers in Burkina Faso are fighting terrorism. So where is our Minister for Defence? Why is he not on the flight to Burkina Faso? And they are here singing “Pwalugu”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Nitiwul, your time is up. Yes, Hon Agalga, you have the floor. It is now 6:26 p.m.

Mr James Agalga (NDC — Builsa North): Mr Speaker, it is sad to hear my Brother, Hon Samuel Abdulai Jinapor, state in his contribution to this particular Statement that they introduced the Accra Initiative to fight terrorism. The facts are very clear. Accra Initiative was birthed by them. But by December 2022, they had completely destroyed the Accra Initiative. When former President Akufo-Addo set foot in Washington and reported to Antony Blinken, in fact, he snitched on the Burkinabes, when he told Antony Blinken, the then Secretary of State of the United States, that Burkina Faso had brought the Wagner Forces to help them fight terrorism. That was the day Burkina Faso withdrew from the Accra Initiative. Mr Speaker, that was the day Burkina Faso refused to collaborate with Ghana in terms of intelligence sharing to deal with terrorism.

6:27 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when President Mahama became president, he decided that there was need for us to have continuous collaboration with the Burkinabes and

that is why he immediately appointed a special envoy in the person of Colonel (Rtd) Gbevlo-Lartey to continue to liaise with the Burkinabes, the Malians and the Nigerians in our quest to fight terrorism. So, I am very disappointed that today our Colleagues on the other Side are saying that the reason why Ghanaians were killed in Burkina Faso is because we glorified a head of state, Ibrahim Traoré, in our country and that is why Ghanaians are being attacked. That is the most irresponsible statement that can come from that Side of the House. Mr Speaker, why? Is Ibrahim Traoré not a head of state?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have spoken for only two minutes.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Hon James Agalga is a respected Member of this House. He cannot in commenting on an important matter like this and tell this House that the former President of this country snitched on another country. Very unacceptable. *[Uproar]* This should not be coming from him. He should not use that language in this House. It is unparliamentary. Mr Speaker, he cannot substantiate this. He cannot use this privilege to use words unbecoming of a Member of Parliament against the former President. If this is said about President Mahama, they will not be happy. I will not accept him using this against President Akufo-Addo.

Mr Speaker, Members of Parliament must rely on facts in their argument. How can he say a President of his country, a country he loves, met a US diplomat and snitched on another

country? And we seem to be accepting this? Hon Agalga should know better and I know he knows better. There is no fact supporting that claim and I plead, Mr Speaker, that you order those statements that President Akufo-Addo snitched on Burkina Faso to be expunged from the record. Mr Speaker, I have said before and I am repeating for the umpteenth time that the National Democratic Congress (NDC) members in this Chamber are opening the Pandora box. They are in government. Respectfully, Colleagues, let us get serious. Respectfully, this is the second attempt with the first attempt attacking Dr Bawumia. They are now attacking H.E. Akufo-Addo. Do not let it be that when Hon Members start using unbecoming language they will now call the Speaker to caution. Stop it. Let us have a free-flow debate. Let us discuss the issues. It is a sad situation. People have died, families are grieving and we as Members of Parliament are trivialising it and thinking that it is something to play politics with.

Mr Speaker, please I will conclude by humbly urging on Mr Speaker in the first instance on Hon Atta-Mills, he did not withdraw the unbecoming comment against Dr Bawumia. Mr Speaker only asked him to move away from there. Now he is also repeating. I would plead for the sake of tomorrow that Mr Speaker asks him to withdraw. He should withdraw.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you have heard the Hon Minority Leader.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, I am surprised that the Minority Leader is speaking this way. He should advert his mind to the meaning of the word I used which is snitch. I know he is somebody who loves English literature. I am surprised at him today, Mr Speaker. Snitch simply means to inform, an informant. Mr Speaker, it is so clear, with the greatest respect.

[Uproar]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon James Agalga, do the needful. Let me give you the rest of your time to continue. Please do the needful.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, to say that somebody informed—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do the needful.

Hon Majority Leader — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, with all due respect.

[Uproar]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, just a moment. *[Uproar]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think you can see that today I am in a mood to listen to everybody but I will be firm. So, Hon James Agalga, do the needful.

Mr Agalga: Very well. Mr Speaker, I will withdraw the word snitch and

substitute same with inform which is synonymous. [*Uproar*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I have ordered him to withdraw. He has withdrawn. I will ask that the word informant should also be expunged from the record. But to use the word informed I do not think that is unparliamentary. But snitch and informant are unparliamentary so they are withdrawn.

You have three more minutes and it is now 6:35 p.m.

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, the point I am making is that the Accra Initiative died a natural death when President Akufo-Addo informed the United States Secretary of State that Burkina Faso had hired the Wagner forces to help it fight terrorism. Mr Speaker, what was the response of Burkina Faso? Burkina Faso immediately recalled its Ambassador here in Accra because of that comment. In fact, the President of Ghana at the time caused a diplomatic row between us and Burkina Faso. That is how collaboration between Ghana and Burkina Faso came to a complete halt.

Mr Speaker, when President Mahama assumed the realms of governance in this country realising the need for us to continue to have a link in our quest to fight terrorism, he appointed a special envoy who continued to work closely with the Burkinabes and the Malians to ensure that our national security apparatus was on top of intelligence and had the ability to help us fight terrorism. And so, I am surprised that my Brothers, Hon S.A. Jinapor and Hon Dominic

Nitiwul are making the case that the reason why Ghanaians have been attacked is because we are not on top of intelligence. No, we are on top of intelligence. What they need to understand is that terrorism is constantly evolving and so what happened in Burkina Faso is a case study. Let us ask ourselves, why are the Burkinabes now attacking Ghanaians? It is because the terrorists believe that if they allow Ghana and Burkina Faso to forge the kind of partnership the two Presidents and of course the other leaders of the Alliance for Sahelian States are trying to forge, they will be weaker. That is the reason. Any security analyst should advert their mind to these facts. And so, they would want to attack Ghanaians so that Ghanaians will begin to speak like the way the former Minister for Defence has spoken and I am very disappointed. So, we would continue to collaborate with the Burkinabes.

6:37 p.m.

Ibrahim Traore, the President of Burkina Faso, is the Head of State of a sovereign nation. They cannot say that our President, who is also the Head of State, should not have dealings with another Head of State. I mean, where is this coming from? That is the impression they created. *City News* reported that one of the reasons the Hon Member ascribed to the attacks on Ghanaians is that we have glorified Ibrahim Traore in this country. That Statement is regrettable, and I am disappointed.

Mr Speaker, I would want to make the point that Ghana and Burkina Faso are brotherly nations. We are brotherly nations and must continue to work together. We have not glorified any coup maker. Ibrahim Traore is the President of

Burkina Faso and deserves to have collaborations with this country.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up. I will proceed to give the floor to the Minority Leader.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, I yield to the Hon Member for Manhyia South to take the slot for the Leader.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have the floor. The time is 6:39 p.m.

Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Minority Leader for yielding to me. I would want to start by expressing my condolences to the bereaved family. And to those who suffered injuries, I wish them a speedy recovery.

Mr Speaker, I would want to put on record that at no point and under no circumstance did Burkina Faso withdraw its Ambassador from the Republic of Ghana. Contrary to the facts expressed by my Brother, Hon Agalga, the Ambassador remains in the Republic of Ghana. He is a former Chief of Defence Staff, who continues to remain in the Republic of Ghana. The representative of the Accra Initiative from Burkina Faso continues to remain in Ghana. At no point did the Accra Initiative collapse.

Mr Speaker, indeed, it should also be captured on record that with all that Hon Agalga has stated in this House, that at

no point was there a terrorist attack—
[Interruption]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you spoke for two minutes. Yes, Hon James Agalga?

Mr Agalga: Mr Speaker, in my submissions, I used appropriate words. I never stated anywhere that the Ambassador was withdrawn. I said he was recalled. To recall an ambassador is not the same as to withdraw. There is a distinction between a recall and a withdrawal. So, he should please not misquote me.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, it is now 6:42 p.m., so you would end at 6:45 p.m.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, I have watched speakers from the other Side of the aisle, and none of them consoled the bereaved family. Yesterday, I was watching television and chills went down my spine when a mother stated that her child had been buried in Burkina Faso, whom she would never get to see.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, hold it.

Hon Members, with all due respect, where I sit, if you use objectionable language, I know. I have listened to everybody. You know it is not factually correct that none of the speakers from the other Side consoled the bereaved family.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, they may correct it when they have the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, with all due respect, I listened to everybody. Please, hold it. I know when you use objectionable language. That is the instances where I would want to take objection from the other Side.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Yesterday, while watching television, I watched a woman deeply in pain crying over the bereavement of her child. The woman said, “So, I could not get to see the remains of my child”. That really sent chills down my spine. It could have been my mother. It could have been the trader in Subin Valley in my Constituency. It could have been the trader in Kejetia. It could have been the trader in Bantama.

Mr Speaker, is it because they are not the suit-wearing, flowery-speaking politician friends that we cannot show sympathy to? We could have commented on these Statements with a bit more solemnity. We did that when our Colleagues, very respectfully, were called to their maker. They cried with us when the nation was in mourning. Mr Speaker, they are the reason we are in this Chamber. Because they are not one of us, there is no national mourning. Because they are not one of us, it took days for a Statement to be issued, and now they are here singing Pwalugu Dam. That is the height of insensitivity.

Mr Speaker, the Komenda Sugar Factory, *w'anwine ne se*. Yet, they are talking about Pwalugu Dam. There is a fundamental question which has been confirmed by my Brother Agalga. He says that there is a case study. What is the case study? Is it because of the relationship between our President and the President of Burkina Faso that has resulted in this? Indeed, that is an admission that there is a need for an enquiry. This House cannot gloss over that necessity. Otherwise, our insensitivity, very respectfully, is going to offend Ghanaians the more. The necessity for an enquiry has been confirmed by Mr Agalga.

And therefore, Mr Speaker, we are inviting you—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, we are inviting you to make an order referring this matter for an enquiry.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jinapor, I think what you are doing is urging him to be disorderly. I do not expect you, as a Senior Member of the House, to ask the Hon Member to ignore me and continue talking.

Yes, it is now time for the Majority Leader. Yes, you are yielding. Hon Member, you have the floor. You have five minutes.

Ms Millicent Yeboah Amankwah (NDC — Sunyani West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on this very important Statement.

Mr Speaker, the rise of these activities is one thing we need to condemn. It was senseless, and not something we should encourage. As a young woman, listening to how this issue is being politicised is one thing we need to condemn.

6:47 p.m.

When there are current issues, let us look for solutions to solve them. The blame game in this Chamber is becoming unbecoming. In matters like this, when I look at my Colleague woman, who because of her life and her family and the need to travel, what happened then at the end? As Leaders, we sit here, and we want to blame the Government because the situation just happened. Mr Speaker, we are leaders, and we need to contribute and have a way to solve this matter.

Mr Speaker, these women were traders and it is essential to talk about this matter because they help us with some livelihoods. So, I would encourage all the leaders in the sub-region to help improve the security issues that is costing us a lot, because we cannot tell where we find ourselves tomorrow.

So, I would encourage the Government to continue to invest in agriculture, so that we get our women to stay here in Ghana, just like the Feed Ghana Initiative and many more. Mr Speaker, again, I would plead with some institutions, such as Microfinance and Small Loans Centre (MASLOC) and other institutions that support women, because we can imagine the capital of

these women, who, when coming back, lose their lives. I can imagine how other families are going to even live.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I would plead with all the leaders to come together, to find solutions, because issues like this in the sub-region affect all countries in West Africa. So, Mr Speaker, enough of the usual politics for the day.

Mr Speaker, I will take this opportunity to express my condolences to the bereaved families because it is not easy. I say this because sometimes I imagine myself as a single mother; majority of them are single mothers and they need to work and feed their families.

I watched some comments from men and I get so sad. Let us come together as one and look for solutions to assist the entire country. Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have come to the end of that Statement.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we had earlier agreed to do two main Statements and we made concessions for our friends on the other Side to make a Statement on the Burkina Faso issue, which has taken us through quite some heated discussions. But the two Statements that we promised to take, we have not taken them. So, it is my plea that we allow the First Deputy Whip on the Majority Side to make a one-page

Statement on an incident that is also very current, which is the stealing of a baby yesterday at Mamprobi Polyclinic. We may not even take comments on that and then we can adjourn for the day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader, that is the application on the Floor.

Hon Minority Leader, when it comes to application, I hear from the Leaders rather than from the back.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the request is coming from a Leader and this is a gender-sensitive matter. So, Mr Speaker, this Side of the House has no objection, except to remind them that one good turn deserves another.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statement standing in the name of the First Deputy Majority Whip and Member of Parliament for Ada.

Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, you have the floor.

Commendation of the Police and the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection for Rescuing a Stolen Baby

Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe (NDC — Ada): Mr Speaker, I am grateful to make this urgent Statement on an incident that has caught the attention of the Ghanaian society on Tuesday, 17th February, 2026, with regard to the rescue of a baby that was stolen from the mother at Mamprobi Polyclinic while the

nursing mother was recovering from a Caesarian operation she underwent a few days ago.

Mr Speaker, I would like to commend the swift and professional action of the Ghana Police Service and the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, led by its Sector Minister, Hon Naa Momo Lartey, following the successful arrest of the woman involved in the theft of the baby at the Mamprobi Polyclinic, Accra.

The timely intervention of the security agencies and the Ministry ensured the safe rescue of the baby and the immediate reunification of the child with the biological mother. This outcome reflects the effectiveness of the inter-agency collaboration and the commitment of our state institutions to the protection of children and vulnerable persons.

Mr Speaker, my appreciation goes to the police officers and the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, whose diligence, sensitivity and professionalism brought this distressed incident to a safe and reassuring conclusion. Their actions have restored public confidence and brought relief to the affected families and the wider community.

Mr Speaker, while commending their efforts, it is important that effective steps are taken to enhance security measures across public and private health facilities nationwide. Hospitals and clinics must strengthen access control, surveillance systems, and staff vigilance to forestall

similar incidents in the future. Protecting mothers, newborn babies and patients must remain a top priority within our healthcare system.

Mr Speaker, I urge the Ministry of Health, with Parliament's commitment to support policies and resource allocation that would improve security infrastructure in health facilities and safeguard the welfare of children across the country.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

6:57 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Statement is ably made. I will give the floor to Hon Patricia Appiagyei.

Ms Patricia Appiagyei (NPP — Asokwa): Thank you Mr Speaker. I would like to commend the maker of the Statement, our own President of the Women's Caucus, for taking such a prompt action of what happened two days ago. In commending her for the Statement, I would also like to commend the alertness of the security within the vicinity. I am sure that having worked there for some time, they have been observing certain activities and it is very important that these activities are brought to the attention of the administrators. The necessary security actions that need to be imposed at the time of visits of the hospital is very much required.

What happens, Mr Speaker, is that if we allow people to just pop in at any time in the hospitals, that is when we have unguided situations where a visitor can just come and steal babies away. It is very disheartening to note that a mother, having carried a baby for nine months, comes in, have a child— and even look at the condition in which she was in, the temperature rise and all that, it is something that any mother will feel strongly about. It is important that we take the necessary measures to ensure that once the babies are born, where we keep them— Over here, I think my observation has been one, that babies are kept by the bedside of their mothers. When it happens like that, when the mother goes out to either have a wash or even go to the restroom, it is not safe for the baby. I think we should be taking all these things into consideration and come up with the best security measures to ensure that when we have our babies, nobody has access to those babies and mothers will feel safe when they deliver.

It is my wish and my plea that the administrators of these hospitals would take a very serious view of this situation and ensure that the measures that they are going to take would take immediate effect and it will not be delayed. I will take this opportunity to commend all the security guards who identified what was happening. They had the sense to identify what was happening and were able to detect and save the child for the mother. I thank the maker of this Statement and I thank the hospital administrators for taking immediate action on this issue.

We, as women, are very grateful, but very much alert that the right decisions will be made. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Leadership, I need some guidance as to the number that we are taking.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we have done five hours, so we are in your hands. I think we agreed that we will just take her Statement and then one comment and then we will call it a day.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. On this note, that brings us to the end of the Statement for the day.

Hon Members, as indicated by the Majority Leader, we have gone beyond five hours. Fortified by Order 56(2), I will proceed to adjourn the House.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 7:03p.m. till Friday, 20th February, 2026, at 12:00 noon.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 28th February, 2026.